

CITY: PG 3

Delhi in full bloom as CM Rekha Gupta unveils Flower Festival '26



NATION: PG 6

Over Rs 5K crore boost for Navy, Coast Guard



FILM: PG 14

'No excuse for online bullying against Arjun'



IRAN STRIKES VITAL INFRASTRUCTURE; TRUMP SAYS TEHRAN'S AIR FORCE, NAVY, LEADERSHIP ELIMINATED

DAY 4: WAR DEEPENS, CLAIMS FLY

Tehran building of Supreme Leader electors targeted | Iran strikes US Embassy in Saudi Arabia

WASHINGTON/ DUBAI/ MOSCOW: On the fourth day of a joint US-Israel attack on Iran which triggered retaliatory strikes and brought the Middle East to the brink of full fledged war, U.S. President Donald Trump on Tuesday claimed Iran's Air Force and Navy had been destroyed and its leadership structure – starting with Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei – eliminated.

In a brief Truth Social post, in which the US President shared an opinion published by the Washington Post – 'We're witnessing the birth of the Trump doctrine' – he crowed: "Their air defense, Air Force, Navy, and Leadership is gone. They want to talk. I said 'Too Late!'"

This comes following Trump's earlier comments that the US has "the capability to go far longer" than its projected four-to-five-week time frame for its military operations against Iran.

US-Israel airstrikes have killed at least 787 people in Iran since the start of the war, the Iranian Red Crescent Society said Tuesday in a message on X. Earlier, President Trump, suggested in an interview to New York Post that he was not ruling out the possibility of sending US military on ground and left open the



This picture, released by the Iranian government's foreign media department and distributed by the AP without changes, shows coffins being carried before a funeral procession for the victims, mostly children, of what Iranian officials said was an Israeli-U.S. strike Feb. 28 at a girls' elementary school in Minab, Iran

WAR RAGES

» Trump: Their air defense, Air Force, Navy, and Leadership is gone. They want to talk. I said 'Too Late!'

» As the conflict in the region intensifies, Trump said that the US has 'the capability to go far longer' than its projected four-to-five-week time frame for its military operations against Iran

» Tehran and its allies have hit back against Israel, neighbouring Gulf states, and targets critical to the world's production of oil and natural gas

» The intensity of the attacks and the lack of any apparent exit plan set the stage for a prolonged conflict with far-reaching consequences

Oil prices surge 8%

NEW YORK: Oil prices soared about 8% to their highest since July 2024 on Tuesday, rising for a third session as the US-Israel war against Iran intensified.

On Tuesday, the price for a barrel of Brent crude, the international standard, leaped another 7.8% to \$83.84. That's up from close to \$70 less than a week ago. A barrel of benchmark US crude, meanwhile, rose 8.8% to \$77.52.

Oil prices made the jump as Iran struck the US Embassy in Saudi Arabia, part of a widening of targets that also includes areas critical to the world's oil and natural gas production.

Worries are particularly high about the Strait of Hormuz off the coast of Iran, a narrow passage-way where roughly a fifth of the world's oil passes. That makes it crucial for the global flow of crude.

See P 11

Fuel stocks safe for 6–8 weeks

Ministry sets up 24x7 control room to track fuel supply

NEW DELHI: India holds sufficient crude and fuel inventories to meet domestic demand for petrol, diesel, and other fuels for six to eight weeks, top government sources said, cushioning the country against any short-term supply disruption amid escalating military conflict in West Asia.

About half of India's crude and LPG imports transit the Strait of Hormuz – the key energy chokepoint that has seen disruptions following US and Israeli attacks

on Iranian government, military and nuclear facilities. Iran warned shipping away from the strait, and insurers withdrew coverage, effectively halting tanker movements.

A top oil ministry official, who wished not to be named, said the government is monitoring the situation "on a daily and hourly basis" and is confident of navigating through the crisis that by some estimates may last a week or ten days. While the country has crude oil stocks to

Continued on P4

Indian students shifted from Tehran

Only a few declined the Embassy's relocation offer

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday said its mission in Iran has relocated the majority of Indian students from Tehran in view of the precarious security situation in the Iranian capital city.

India's move came as the conflict in West Asia intensified with the US and Israel carrying out fresh attacks on Iran while Tehran continued

to pound several Gulf countries in retaliation.

"Due to the heightened risk perception in Tehran city, the embassy of India has relocated most Indian students who were in 'Tehran,' the Indian mission said.

The students were taken to locations outside of Tehran.

The embassy said it has made arrangements for

the transportation, food, and accommodation of the students.

"Only a small number of students who declined the embassy's offer remain in 'Tehran,' it said.

"For other Indian students and Indian nationals who still remain in Iran, the advisory issued earlier remains unchanged: Continued on P4

FBI PROBES EXTREMIST LINKS

Indian-American among 4 dead in Texas shooting

HOUSTON: A 21-year-old Indian-American student is among four killed in a shooting outside a bar in Austin that is being investigated as a possible act of terrorism.

Savitha Shan, an Austin native and a dual-degree senior at the University of Texas at Austin, was fatally shot when a gunman opened fire in a crowded entertainment district on West Sixth Street on Sunday.

She was months away from graduation and was described by university officials as an outstanding student leader studying management information systems and economics.

The identities of the two persons who died at the scene of the shooting have been confirmed by Chief Lisa Davis of the Austin police at a news conference on Monday afternoon. They are Ryder Harrington, 19, and Shan.

The Indian-American community in Texas is mourning after Shan was identified as one of the victims of Sunday's

Continued on P4

Nitin Nabin, party chief, in BJP's 9 RS list

Former Bengal unit chief, Chhattisgarh unit vice-president among nominees

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: BJP national president Nitin Nabin was on Tuesday nominated as the party's candidate from Bihar for the upcoming Rajya Sabha polls.

The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has released a list of nine candidates for the Rajya Sabha polls, fielding its former West Bengal unit chief Rahul Sinha and Chhattisgarh unit vice-president Laxmi Verma from the respective states.

Assam PWD Minister Jogen Mohan and MLA Terash Gowalla will be the saffron party's candidates from the state for the



BJP national president Nitin Nabin during 'Holi Milan Samaroh', in Patna, on Tuesday

election to the Upper House of Parliament.

The BJP has also nominated its Odisha unit president, Manmohan

SHORTLIST

» Assam PWD Minister Jogen Mohan and MLA Terash Gowalla will be the saffron party's candidates from the state

» BJP leader Shivesh Kumar will join the fray from Bihar and Sanjay Bhatia, a former Lok Sabha MP of the party, will be its candidate from Haryana

BJP leader Shivesh Kumar will join the fray from Bihar and Sanjay Bhatia, a former Lok Sabha MP of the party, will be its candidate from Haryana. Kumar is Bihar BJP's general secretary.

The names of the candidates have been approved by the party's central election committee, BJP national general secretary Arun Singh said.

Nabin's nomination for the Rajya Sabha polls from Bihar was expected since he was elected unopposed as the BJP's 12th national president in January. At present, he is an MLA from the Bankipur Assembly constituency in Bihar.

Continued on P4

LUNAR SPECTACLE



The moon is seen during the lunar eclipse beside India Gate, on Tuesday

PTI

SEES INDIA IN GLOBAL SUPPLY CHAIN

PM Modi urges industry leaders to invest, innovate

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday urged industry leaders to step up investments, embrace emerging technologies and prioritise research to leverage the vast opportunities offered by free trade agreements with various nations.

Addressing the second webinar on Budget 2026-27, he said, the world is now looking for reliable and resilient manufacturing partners, and India has the opportunity to play this role decisively and enhance the country's participation in the global supply chain.

For this, PM Modi said, "all stakeholders must invest with confidence, adopt new technol-

ogies, and significantly increase investment in research – those days of being frugal in research are over. We must ensure quality in line with global standards. As I often say, when opportunities arise to move ahead, we must have only one mantra -- Quality, Quality, Quality."

Stressing that India has entered into free trade agreements with numerous countries, he said, these agreements have opened up a wide range of opportunities for the country.

"In such a situation, he said, "our responsibility is that we should never compromise on quality. If there is one area where we must apply maximum strength, intelligence, and focus,



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

PTI

it is quality. Our products must meet global standards," he said.

For this, he said, "We need to study the needs and expectations of other countries and con-

duct thorough research. We must understand the preferences and comfort of consumers in those markets. In today's competitive world, quality is what gives us

a golden opportunity. We must create user-friendly products tailored to their needs."

Only then can India truly benefit from the opportunities opened

CLOSER LOOK

» 'All stakeholders must invest with confidence, adopt new technologies, and significantly increase investment in research – those days of being frugal in research are over'

» 'We must ensure quality in line with global standards. As I often say, when opportunities arise to move ahead, we must have only one mantra -- Quality, Quality, Quality'

» Stressing that India has entered into free trade agreements with numerous countries, he said, these agreements have opened up a wide range of opportunities for the country

by various free trade agreements, which have created a highway of growth for you, he said.

Today, the world is seeking reliable and resilient manufacturing partners, he said, adding that India has a strong opportunity to fulfil this role.

"Our direction is clear. Our resolve is clear. Build more, produce more, connect more, and now the need is to export more," he said.

He urged participants at the webinar to prioritise key issues such as ways to increase manufacturing and production, make cost structures more competitive, accelerate investment flows, and ensure that development reaches every corner of the country.

Continued on P4



millenniumpost

wishes its readers a Happy Holi. Our office will remain closed on March 4. There will be no edition on March 5.



World Wildlife Day is about celebrating incredible faunal diversity

PM Modi

In today's paper

CITY	
DELHI GETS WARMER AT 31.5°C	2
NATION	
HEAVY SECURITY IN UP	6
EDIT	
MANAGING UNWANTED FALLOUT	7
INTERNATIONAL	
BRITAIN SENDING WARSHIP TO CYPRUS 8	
BUSINESS	
ADVISORY ISSUED FOR MARITIME OPERATORS	10
SPORT	
SEN STUNS YU QUI	12

DELHI POLICE'S 'OPERATION AAGHAT'

204 nabbed, preventive sections slapped on 973

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Under 'Operation Aaghat' against habitual offenders, bootleggers, drug peddlers and other miscreants ahead of Holi, the southern range of Delhi Police has arrested 204 people and invoked preventive provisions against 973 individuals, a senior officer said on Tuesday.

He said the "intelligence-led" operation was conducted across south and southeast districts as a synchronised crackdown on bad characters to ensure peaceful celebrations of the festival.

According to data shared by the police, 204 people were arrested under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Arms Act, Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, Delhi Excise Act and Public Gambling Act.

"In addition, 973 persons were apprehended under preventive sections during area domination exercises and verification drives," the officer said.

He said four proclaimed offenders and 29 bad characters were also arrested as part of the operation.



Four proclaimed offenders and 29 bad characters were also arrested as part of op

An officer from southeast district said 137 accused were arrested in the district and 449 persons apprehended under preventive provisions. One proclaimed offender was held.

Police also issued 63 challans under the cigarettes and tobacco product act (COTPA) and recovered Rs 11,500 as fine, besides depositing 273 vehicles under the Delhi Police Act.

In the south district, 67 people were arrested, 524 persons apprehended preventively and three proclaimed offenders were nabbed. As many as 29 habitual offenders were also taken into custody during the drive, an officer said.

"As part of the crackdown on street and property crime, six property offenders were arrested across the southern range. Police arrested one auto-lifter and recovered nine stolen motorcycles. Multiple abandoned and suspicious vehicles were also seized during area checks," the officer said.

The operation led to significant recoveries, including 12 illegal firearms, 14 live cartridges and 24 knives. Police seized 7.197 kg of cannabis and 12.7 grams of MDMA, along with 15,945 bottles of illicit liquor. A total of Rs 84,740 in cash was seized in gambling cases.

Top-level shake-up in Delhi Police; special, joint, DCP ranks reshuffled

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police on Tuesday saw a major reshuffle in the brass, with the city government ordering the transfer and posting of 50 IPS and 20 DANIPS officers across key positions with immediate effect, according to an official order.

The order, issued with the approval of the lieutenant governor, effected changes at levels including that of special commissioners, joint commissioners, additional commissioners and deputy commissioners of police (DCPs), impacting district policing, crime, traffic, security and specialised units.

Among senior-level changes, Sanjay Kumar Jain has been posted as the Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to the Commissioner of Police, with the additional charge of Joint Commissioner of Police (Tech and PI), while Joint Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Kime Kamjing has been appointed as the Joint CP (Armed Police).

Dheeraj Kumar moves from the post of Joint CP (Armed Police) to the position of Joint CP (Crime), heading the Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF). Ajit Kumar Singla has been posted as the Joint CP (Eastern Range) and Sanjay Kumar Tyagi takes over as the Joint CP (Traffic).



A police officer said the large-scale exercise is aimed at administrative streamlining

At the additional commissioner level, Monika Bhardwaj has been shifted from traffic to the position of Additional CP (IFSO), while Vijyanta Arya has been posted as the Additional CP (Traffic). Satya Vir Katara has been given the charge of the Additional CP (Recruitment) and Nidhin Val-san moves to the position of Additional CP (Tech and PI). Abhishek Dhania has been posted as the Additional CP (Crime-ANTF).

Several district-level changes were also announced. Sachin Sharma, who was serving as the DCP (Outer) will take charge as the DCP (New Delhi), while DCP (Traffic)

HIGHLIGHTS

» Sanjay Kumar Jain has been posted as the Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to the Commissioner of Police, with the additional charge of Joint Commissioner of Police (Tech and PI)

» Dheeraj Kumar moves from the post of Joint CP (Armed Police) to the position of Joint CP (Crime), heading the Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF)

and Ankit Kumar Singh, who was the DCP (Dwarka), has been given the post of DCP (Vigilance).

Shobhit D Saxena has been posted as the DCP (Traffic), while Bharat Reddy Bommarreddy takes charge as the DCP (Railways), with the additional charge of DCP (Metro).

Among other key postings, Sudhanshu Verma has been appointed as the DCP (Security-PM), Sandeep Gupta as the DCP (Traffic), Vineet Kumar as the DCP (Tech and PI) and Sumit Kumar Jha as the DCP (CP's Secretariat-Crime).

In the DANIPS cadre, multiple ACs have been assigned additional DCP responsibilities in current duty-charge arrangements across districts including Shahdara, North, Outer, South-East and Rohini, as part of the wider administrative exercise.

The reshuffle also includes the transfer of senior Indian Police Service (IPS) officers Virender Singh to the position of DG (Home Guards), Anand Mohan to the post of DG (Prisons) and Surendra Singh Yadav to the position of DG (Civil Defence).

A senior police officer said the large-scale exercise is aimed at administrative streamlining and strengthening policing across districts and specialised units in the national capital.

Two children among 7 injured in cylinder blast in Swaroop Ngr

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: At least seven people, including two children and three women, were injured after a small LPG cylinder exploded in a residential building in outernorth Delhi's Swaroop Nagar on Tuesday, an official said.

The incident occurred in the morning hours at a house in Swaroop Nagar. Police said the blast occurred in a room on the third floor of the building, which was occupied by a tenant family comprising four members.

"A small LPG cylinder exploded inside a room on the third floor of the house. The police team reached the spot immediately after receiving information. The fire was brought under control, and further inquiry is underway," a senior police officer said.

Five people, including a woman and two children who were on the third floor during the explosion, sustained injuries. Additionally, two women residing on the second floor were also injured due to the blast's impact, police said.

All the injured were shifted to a hospital in Burari for treatment. The explosion caused panic in the area, with residents rushing out of their homes after hearing a loud noise. Police said they are verifying the cause of the cylinder blast and examining whether any negligence was involved.

"Appropriate legal action will be taken according to the law based on the findings of the inquiry," the officer said.

Four held for running online cricket betting racket

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested four men for allegedly running an illegal online cricket betting racket with links to Dubai from a flat in Paschim Vihar. Acting on a tip-off, officers raided the premises on March 1 and apprehended the accused as they allegedly tried to flee. Seven mobile phones, three laptops and other materials were seized. An FIR has been registered and further investigation is under way. **MPOST**

Police: 134 intersections under watch; drunken driving to cost three-month licence suspension

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Traffic Police will deploy personnel at around 134 major intersections across the city on Holi on March 4, with strict enforcement against drunken driving and a provision for suspension of driving licences for a minimum of three months in serious violations, an official said on Tuesday.

Issuing a detailed traffic advisory, the police said special checking teams will be stationed at major junctions and vulnerable stretches to curb offences such as drunken driving, over-speeding, reckless and zig-zag driving, red-light jumping, triple riding, riding without helmets and performing stunts on two-wheelers.

According to the directions of the Supreme Court Committee on Road Safety,



in cases of drunken driving, red-light jumping, using a mobile phone while driving, dangerous driving and over-speeding, the driving licence of the offender will be seized and liable for suspension for at least three months, the advisory stated.

Action will also be initiated against registered owners if their vehicles are found to be driven by minors or unauthorised persons.

'Action will also be initiated against registered owners if their vehicles are found to be driven by minors'

Additional Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Dinesh Gupta said elaborate arrangements have been put in place to ensure pedestrian and motorist safety.

"Keeping the Holi festival in mind, the Delhi Traffic Police has issued a detailed traffic management plan. Our staff will be deployed at around 134 major intersections. Personnel will remain present across key areas, and senior officers

will supervise the arrangements. Our primary focus will be to prevent drunken driving," Gupta said.

He added that strict action would be taken against those driving without helmets, driving on the wrong side or indulging in dangerous driving.

"We will make every possible effort to curb all traffic violations, and appropriate action will be taken wherever violations are found," he said.

The advisory said PCR vans and local police teams will assist traffic personnel in enforcing norms across the city.

Gupta also warned that violations highlighted on social media will not be ignored. "If we see any violation on social media which is uploaded by someone, then we will take action on it and we keep on monitoring it continuously," he said.

3 held over stock investment fraud

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested three men and bound down a woman over alleged links to a cyber fraud module that cheated a grocery shop owner in north-west Delhi of Rs 17 lakh on the pretext of stock market investments, an official said on Tuesday.

The arrests were made in connection with an online fraud case registered in January. The accused have been identified as Inderjeet (38), Pawan Kumar (38) and Gaurav Tyagi (25). A woman, Mahima Sharma (24), was bound down (to join investigation whenever called).

According to the police, the case came to light after Yogesh Kumar (43), who runs a grocery shop in Shalimar Bagh, lodged a complaint alleging that he was added to a social media group where fraudsters lured him with promises of high returns in stock market investments.

He was provided a registration link and directed to transfer money into multiple bank accounts.

"In this manner, he invested around Rs 17.10 lakh. When he attempted to withdraw the amount, he was asked to deposit additional money, which raised suspicion. He then approached the police," the officer said.

An e-FIR was registered



on January 18 and investigation was taken up.

During the probe, police conducted a detailed financial analysis of the money trail and found that the cheated amount was allegedly routed through a 'mule' bank account linked to a firm operated by Inderjeet, the officer said. The transaction pattern showed high-value credits followed by immediate diversion of funds through gaming applications and other digital platforms to conceal the trail, he added.

"Inderjeet had deliberately provided his firm's current bank account to a cyber fraud syndicate on commission basis. Pawan allegedly acted as a mediator in arranging bank accounts, while Gaurav assisted in coordination and operational handling. The role of the woman is under investigation," the officer said.

Police recovered three mobile phones allegedly used in the crime; further investigation is under way, officials said.

Scooty rider killed after hitting open car door, run over by bus

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 30-year-old man was killed in a road accident near Uttam Nagar West Metro Station on February 3 after his scooter struck the open door of a parked Toyota Etios and he was subsequently run over by a Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) bus.

Police said a PCR call reporting the incident was received at Uttam Nagar Police Station on the evening of February 3. A team reached the spot and found three vehicles involved — a DTC bus, the scooter and a Toyota Etios car.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that the Toyota had stopped on the left side of the road after a passenger requested the driver to halt as he was feeling unwell and needed to use a washroom. While the vehicle was stationary, the passenger opened the right rear door to alight. At that moment, the scooter rider approaching from behind collided with the suddenly opened door.

The impact caused the rider to lose balance and fall on to the road. Within seconds, a DTC bus coming from behind ran over him, leaving bystanders in shock.

The injured man was rushed to Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead. He was identified as Daksh (30), son of Ishwar and a resident of Uttam Nagar. An FIR has been registered under Sections 281 and 106 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and an investigation is under way to establish the precise sequence of events and fix responsibility. Police said statements of witnesses are being recorded and CCTV footage from the area is being examined. Further legal action will follow based on the findings of the probe.

Paschim Vihar: Caretaker nabbed for drugging family, stealing cash

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have arrested a woman caretaker for allegedly stealing cash from her employer's home after mixing sleeping pills into the family's food and rendering them unconscious.

Police said a PCR call was received at Paschim Vihar East Police Station on February 26 regarding a theft of Rs 30,000–40,000 from a residence in BG-02, Paschim Vihar.

According to officers, the family had hired the caretaker through Angel Nursing Healthcare Services LLP in Nihal Vihar after searching online, as a 59-year-old woman in the household was unwell. The

Food samples were seized for analysis, victims were taken to the hospital

caretaker joined duty the same day and prepared lunch for the family. Shortly after consuming the meal, all members allegedly fell unconscious.

Suspecting foul play, police called in the Mobile Forensic Science Laboratory team to examine the scene. Food samples were seized for analysis and the victims were taken to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital for treatment.

An FIR was registered on February 27 under Sections 123 and 303 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and an investigation was initiated.

Using technical surveillance and manual tracking, investigators traced the accused to Bareilly, UP and apprehended her during a raid on February 27. During interrogation, she allegedly confessed to crushing six sleeping pills and mixing them into the food with the intention of committing theft. Police said Rs 20,000 has been recovered at her instance, and efforts are under way to recover the remaining amount. Further investigation is ongoing. **MPOST**

AQI IN 'POOR' CATEGORY, LIKELY TO IMPROVE SLIGHTLY

Delhi gets warmer at 31.5°C; temp to go higher on Holi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded a warm day on Tuesday with a maximum temperature of 31.5 degrees Celsius, 4.1 degrees Celsius above normal.

The minimum temperature was recorded at 15.6 degrees Celsius, 2.2 degrees Celsius above normal.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), on Holi (Wednesday), the maximum temperature is expected to settle at 33 degrees Celsius, while the minimum is likely to be around 16.0 degrees Celsius.

If the mercury reaches 33 degrees Celsius, it could make



Holi the hottest day of the year.

The IMD has forecast a mainly clear sky for tomorrow,

with sustained surface winds of 15-25 kmph, occasionally gusting to 35 kmph during the day.

Relative humidity was recorded at 74% in the morning

Station-wise, Safdarjung recorded a maximum of 31.5 degrees Celsius (4.1 degrees Celsius above normal), Palam 29.4 degrees Celsius (2.4 degrees Celsius above normal), Lodi Road 31.4 degrees Celsius (4.4 degrees Celsius above normal), Ridge 31.5 degrees Celsius (3.5 degrees Celsius above normal), and Ayanagar 31.6 degrees Celsius (4.5 degrees Celsius above normal).

The minimum temperatures were 15.6 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung (2.2 degrees Celsius above normal), 13.8 degrees Celsius at Palam (1.2 degrees Celsius above normal), 14.6 degrees Celsius at Lodhi Road (2.6 degrees Celsius above normal), 17.3 degrees Celsius at Ridge (3.2 degrees Celsius above normal) and 15.1 degrees Celsius at Ayanagar (2.1 degrees Celsius above normal). Relative humidity was recorded at 74 per cent in the morning and 33 per cent in the evening.

The Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 216 in the 'poor' category on Tuesday morning, deteriorating from the 'mod-

erate' category recorded a day earlier. According to the Air Quality Early Warning System, the AQI is likely to remain in the 'moderate' category on Holi and up to March 6.

According to the CPCB, an AQI between zero and 50 is considered 'good'; 51 and 100 'satisfactory'; 101 and 200 'moderate'; 201 and 300 'poor'; 301 and 400 'very poor'; and 401 and 500 'severe'. Its SAMEER app showed 24 stations were in 'poor', 19 stations were in 'moderate', and two stations were in 'very poor' category.

Punjabi Bagh recorded the worst AQI at 389. In the morning hours, the air quality stood at 216 in the 'poor' category.

CENTRAL PARK IN CONNAUGHT PLACE

Delhi in full bloom as CM Rekha Gupta unveils Flower Festival ‘26

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a vibrant celebration of spring and civic pride, Delhi's iconic Central Park in Connaught Place was transformed into a breathtaking floral panorama as Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated the four-day Flower Festival 2026 on Tuesday. Organised by the New Delhi Municipal Council, the festival brings together more than 15,500 flowers of 48 varieties, turning the heart of the national capital into a fragrant showcase of colour, creativity and urban greenery.

Organised by the New Delhi Municipal Council at Central Park, Connaught Place, the festival features over 15,500 potted plants spanning 48 varieties, displayed across 18 themed sections. NDMC Chairman Keshav Chandra and Vice-Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal were also present at the inauguration.



Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister said, "As the national capital, it is our collective responsibility to make Delhi cleaner, greener and more attractive." Highlighting the presence of tulips in the capital, she remarked, "Earlier, people travelled to Kashmir to witness tulips, but today residents can enjoy vibrant tulips and a wide variety of flowers within Delhi itself." Calling it a "Selfie Festival", she noted that the event has emerged as a major attraction for citizens.

The Chief Minister observed that the festival, held during the month of Phalgun, has "filled the capital with colour and fragrance." She praised the gardeners and officials of NDMC's Horticulture Department for their tireless efforts in transforming the venue. "With sustained efforts, the entire city can be adorned with flowers," she said, urging other departments to draw inspiration from such initiatives.

HIGHLIGHTS

» 'As the national capital, it is our collective responsibility to make Delhi cleaner, greener and more attractive'

» Highlighting the presence of tulips, she remarked, 'Earlier, people travelled to Kashmir to witness tulips, but today residents can enjoy vibrant tulips... within Delhi itself'

gunna, has "filled the capital with colour and fragrance." She praised the gardeners and officials of NDMC's Horticulture Department for their tireless efforts in transforming the venue. "With sustained efforts, the entire city can be adorned with flowers," she said, urging other departments to draw inspiration from such initiatives.

Seasonal blooms such as dahlias, petunias, pansies, salvias and marigolds are among the key attractions.

The exhibition also showcases tray gardens, landscape gardens, terrariums, large hanging baskets, Eastern and Western floral arrangements including Ikebana, and floral figures shaped like animals and birds.

Specially designed pyramid, heart-shaped, conical and cylindrical floral structures have been developed as selfie points, along with colourful floral boards.

The festival will remain open to the public from March 3 to March 6 with free entry. Visitors can also explore stalls offering nursery plants, bonsai, cacti, succulents, herbal plants, hydroponic systems, gardening tools, seeds, pots, fertilisers and decorative materials for sale.

Capital to remodel 300 km of drains to tackle waterlogging

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is set to undertake a major overhaul of the city's drainage infrastructure, with plans to remodel 300 kilometres of drains in the upcoming financial year as part of the first phase of a comprehensive Drainage Master Plan, officials said on Tuesday.

The ambitious blueprint, unveiled by the Public Works Department in September last year, is designed to address Delhi's drainage needs for the next three decades. The project will be rolled out over five years in two phases, with an estimated total cost of Rs.57,362 crore. Authorities aim to reduce waterlogging incidents by 50 per cent within three years and cut flood-related accidents by 30 per cent over five years.

A senior government official told reporters that during a recent budget meeting, it was decided that revamp work covering 300 km of drains would begin this year. "Budget requirements for the same will be sent to the government shortly," the official said.



Flood Control Department has announced works including the revamp of 13 drains and construction of 18 roads

Work has already been sanctioned in several chronic waterlogging zones. Tenders have been floated for projects in Azadpur, Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, Nangloi and Khanjawa. The approach, officials said, is to remodel drains along interconnected stretches rather than in isolated patches, ensuring long-term and systematic improvements.

In North Delhi, drain remodelling projects have been approved in Model Town-II, Model Town-III and Kushal Cinema Road, with ₹48.13 crore allocated for these works. Additional stretches are being identified for similar interventions.

The master plan incorporates scientific assessments of slopes, natural depressions and the constraints of existing infrastructure to enhance overall drainage efficiency. Officials said it offers a forward-looking roadmap to modernise the city's ageing system.

Separately, the Irrigation and Flood Control Department has announced works including the revamp of 13 drains and construction of 18 roads and bridges to strengthen rainwater discharge.

Delhi's last drainage master plan dates back to 1976, when the city's population stood at around 60 lakh. Today, the PWD maintains nearly 2,153 km of drains, underscoring the scale of infrastructure now requiring upgradation.

HPV vaccination drive conducted for adolescent girls in south Delhi

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi on conducted a Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccination drive for adolescent girls aged 14–15 years at the Urban Primary Health Centre (UPHC), Fatehpur Beri, in the South Zone. The initiative forms part of the civic body's ongoing public health outreach programmes aimed at strengthening preventive healthcare services at the community level.

According to officials, the drive focused on creating awareness about cervical cancer prevention while ensuring timely immunisation for eligible beneficiaries. Medical staff at the UPHC administered the vaccine and counselled parents and students about the importance of early protection against HPV, a leading cause of cervical cancer among women.

Health authorities said the programme was carried out in an organised manner, with due attention to safety protocols and post-vaccination observation. Informational materials were also distributed to address common concerns and myths surrounding the vaccine.



Ensuring accessible, timely healthcare remains a priority, an official statement noted, adding that similar drives would be conducted across other zones in phases

The MCD reiterated its commitment to expanding access to essential health services, particularly for adolescents and women. "Ensuring accessible and timely healthcare remains a priority," an official statement noted, adding that similar drives would be conducted across other zones in a phased manner.

Public health experts have consistently underlined the significance of HPV vaccination in reducing the long-term burden of cervical cancer. By integrating immunisation efforts within primary healthcare centres, the civic body aims to improve coverage and promote preventive healthcare practices among vulnerable age groups.

The initiative reflects a broader push towards strengthening grassroots healthcare infrastructure in the Capital.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A day after President Droupadi Murmu launched the Delhi government's 'Pink Saheli' smart card scheme, more than 3,500 women obtained their pink cards from around 50 designated distribution centres across the capital on Tuesday.

According to a senior official, 3,622 women approached various centres through the day and were issued the cards on the spot following due verification.

Among them, 3,612 eligible women were issued pink cards, while 10 blue cards were distributed, he said.

"The first day's response is encouraging; we did not expect such a response on the first day and we hopeful to get more in coming days," he added.

The Pink National Common Mobility (PNCM) card was launched on Monday by President Droupadi Murmu. It aims to provide women and transgender persons free travel on DTC and cluster buses, while also enabling access to multiple public transport systems through a single smart card under the 'One Nation, One Card' initiative.



Each pink card will be linked to the beneficiary's Aadhaar and mobile number to verify age, gender and domicile.

The card will replace the existing paper-based pink ticket system and is expected to enable touch-free travel, maintain digital journey records and improve transparency in revenue accounting, according to officials.

While travel on DTC and cluster buses will be free for eligible women residents of Delhi, the card can also be used for paid journeys on other public transport services such as the Delhi Metro and the Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS), allowing commuters to use one card across different networks, they added.

Under the programme, three types of mobility cards will be issued -- pink for eligible women domiciled in Delhi, blue for general commuters and orange for monthly pass users, officials said, adding that in the first phase, pink and blue cards are being rolled out, while the orange card will be introduced later.

The centres set up for issuance include offices of district magistrates and sub-divisional magistrates, along with select Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) locations. Of the nearly 50 centres, 20 are operated by the DTC.

'The card will replace the existing paper-based pink ticket system and is expected to enable touch-free travel, maintain digital journey records...'

The DTC has also authorised Hindon Mercantile Limited (MufinPay) and Airtel Payments Bank Limited to issue the common mobility cards. The cards will be integrated with the existing automatic fare collection system across the city's public transport network, officials said.

City Briefs

MIN MARKS HOLI WITH DIVYANG KIDS

NEW DELHI: Delhi Social Welfare Minister Ravindra Indraj Singh celebrated Holi with divyang and mentally special children at Asha Kiran Home in Rohini, reaffirming his commitment to mark festivals and personal occasions with vulnerable sections. Calling Holi "a symbol of inclusion and social harmony," he said the children's smiles were "true blessings" for the govt. He highlighted ongoing efforts toward healthcare, education and rehabilitation, and informed about a proposed school-cum-home in Usmanpur.

'HOLI SYMBOLISES UNITY, HARMONY'

NEW DELHI: MCD Mayor, Sardar Raja Iqbal Singh, on Tuesday extended his greetings to residents of the Capital on the occasion of Holi, describing the festival as a celebration of joy, harmony and unity. In his message, the Mayor said Holi symbolises the triumph of good over evil and strengthens bonds of brotherhood across communities. He urged citizens to use natural colours, conserve water and maintain cleanliness.

Arvind Kejriwal to appear before Delhi Assembly panel over 'Phansi Ghar' row

NEW DELHI: Former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal on Tuesday wrote to the Delhi Assembly's Privileges Committee confirming his appearance before the panel on March 6 on the 'Phansi Ghar' issue and demanding the live-streaming of proceedings.

The Committee is examining the matter related to a renovated section in the Delhi Assembly that was inaugurated under the AAP dispensation as a British-era Phansi Ghar (execution chamber), while the BJP claims it was a tiffin room.

The panel had scheduled an appearance of Kejriwal and other AAP members in the matter. In his letter to the chairperson of the committee, Kejriwal informed that he will attend the panel hearing on March 6 in compliance with its summons.



"Delhi is grappling with pollution, the roads are broken, there are piles of garbage everywhere, and hospitals are out of medicines. The Delhi Assembly has summoned me to question me about the 'Phansi Ghar', Kejriwal said in a post on X in Hindi. "My appearance is without prejudice to my legal and constitutional rights, remedies, objections and contentions, all of which are expressly reserved," he added in his letter.

"In the interest of transparency and public accountability, I request that the proceedings of the Committee in the present matter be live-streamed," Kejriwal said in his letter.

Last month, the committee scheduled the final in-person appearance of Kejriwal, former deputy chief minister Manish Sisodia, ex-speaker Ram Niwas Goel and former deputy speaker Rakhi Birla for March 6, along with the submission of their statements.

Earlier, on January 6, the Privileges Committee had recommended that the House take appropriate action against the four AAP leaders for not appearing before it the matter.

Speaker Vijender Gupta questioned 'Phansi Ghar' authenticity; PWD said Rs 1.4 crore spent, Assembly summoned Kejriwal and others. MPOST

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested a 26-year-old drug trafficker and seized nearly 800 grams of heroin worth over Rs 5 crore, an official said on Tuesday.

The accused, identified as Mridul Singh Tomar, was apprehended near a mall in east Delhi on February 13 following tip-off.

"A total of 799 grams of heroin was recovered from his possession. An FIR was registered against him and further investigation is underway to identify other members of the supply network," the officer added.

During interrogation, the accused disclosed that he had initially procured small quantities of narcotics for personal consumption before escalating to bulk procurement and distribution in various parts of Delhi over the past month, they said.



The consignment seized was allegedly sourced from Kasim Vihar in Uttar Pradesh, on a profit-sharing basis. The police said Tomar is previously involved in eight criminal cases. Further investigation into the matter is underway. MPOST

Heroin worth ₹5 cr seized; one nabbed

Speaker hosts Holi Milan with diplomats from 31 countries



NEW DELHI: The historic premises of the Delhi Legislative Assembly resonated with colour, culture and diplomacy as Speaker Vijender Gupta hosted a grand Holi Milan, bringing together political leaders and representatives from more than 31 countries in a vibrant celebration of unity and civic responsibility.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta said, "Holi is not just a festival of colours; it is a celebration of India's civilisational strength, our democratic spirit, and the enduring victory of truth and righteousness." He added, "Delhi, as the capital of the world's largest democracy, welcomes the world not only through diplomacy but through culture and shared celebration."

Holi is not just a festival of colours; it is a celebration of India's civilisational strength

The event witnessed the presence of Ambassadors, High Commissioners and members of the diplomatic corps, alongside Union Minister of State for Road Transport and Highways Harsh Mahotra, Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht, Delhi BJP President Virendra Sachdeva and several Members of the Legislative Assembly. Diplomats from countries including Russia, Chile, Sudan, Venezuela, Bangladesh and Vietnam participated, underscoring India's expanding global engagement and the spirit of international friendship.

Reflecting on the festival's deeper meaning, the Speaker referred to the legend of Prahlad and Holika, emphasising that truth and moral courage ultimately prevail. He also invoked the traditions of Radha and Krishna, noting that Holi symbolises harmony and shared humanity beyond boundaries of language and geography.

A documentary on Vithalbhai Patel highlighted his role in strengthening parliamentary traditions. The 90-minute cultural segment featured Kathak, puppet and Mallakhamb performances with folk dances.

Concluding the event, Gupta urged citizens to use herbal gugal, avoid chemical colours and conserve water. MPOST

During the event, Gupta urged citizens to use herbal gugal, avoid chemical colours and conserve water. MPOST

CM Gupta greets Delhiites on Holi

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday extended her greetings to the people of the national capital on the occasion of Holi, describing the festival as a celebration of harmony, unity and shared cultural heritage.

In her message, the Chief Minister said, "Holi is not merely a festival of colours, but a celebration of our shared culture and unity in diversity." She expressed hope that the festival would bring happiness and prosperity to every household and urged citizens to strengthen bonds of brotherhood while working towards an inclusive society.

Highlighting the government's development agenda, she said that just as colours blend to create beauty, her government is committed to connecting every corner of Delhi with modern infrastructure, seamless transport and smart facilities.

She reiterated that strong measures are being taken to curb pollution and improve civic amenities, expressing confidence that the vision of a "Viksit Delhi" will soon become a reality. MPOST

WITH 1,109 SAILORS

At least 37 Indian-flagged ships stuck in Persian Gulf, Gulf of Oman

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As many as 37 Indian-flagged ships with over 1,000 seafarers are stuck in the Persian Gulf, the Gulf of Oman and the adjoining sea areas as the key shipping route through the Strait of Hormuz is closed due to the ongoing military actions involving the United States, Israel and Iran.

While some ships are carrying crude oil and LNG to Indian ports, others are on the way to bring petroleum products from the Gulf nations.

A total of 37 Indian-flagged ships with 1,109 sailors are stuck in the Persian Gulf, the Gulf of Oman and the adjoining sea areas due to the closure of the key shipping route through the Strait of Hormuz, an official privy to the development told news agency.

The Directorate General of Shipping is in regular touch with the shipping companies and is closely monitoring the situation.

At least three Indian seafarers on board foreign-flagged vessels were killed, and one was injured in West Asia due to the current conflict.

Highlights

- » While some ships are carrying crude oil and LNG to Indian ports, others are on the way to bring petroleum products from the Gulf nations
- » At least three Indian seafarers on board foreign-flagged vessels were killed, and one was injured in West Asia due to the current conflict

A dedicated quick response team has been set up by the Shipping Ministry to enable timely coordination among authorities, ensure immediate response to emerging situations and facilitate prompt assistance to Indian seafarers and their families.

Shipping companies and Recruitment and Placement Service Licensees (RPSLs) have been advised to exercise caution in crew deployment and maintain regular communication with seafarers and their families.

Helpline numbers have also been activated and shared with the families of the seafarers through RPSLs.

The Directorate General of Shipping also issued an advisory for maritime operators to assess voyage-specific risks following the disruptions of the shipping route and closure of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran.

It is closely monitoring the evolving maritime security situation in the Persian Gulf, the Strait of Hormuz, the Gulf of Oman and the adjoining sea areas, and the threats of the recent geopolitical developments, including missile and drone activity, electronic interference, and other maritime security concerns.

On Tuesday, Shipping Minister Sarbananda Sonowal chaired a review meeting to assess the prevailing security environment in the Persian Gulf region and examine its implications for Indian maritime assets and personnel.

Close coordination is being maintained with the Indian Navy, the Ministry of External Affairs, the Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR), the Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre (MRCC) and Indian missions abroad.

Continued from Page 1
Possibility for a more extensive US military operation.

US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth in a press briefing on Monday had said that the Trump administration would not get into the “foolish” exercise of telegraphing “what we will or will not do.”

White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt announced that “49 of the most senior Iranian regime leaders” have been killed in the US-Israeli strikes on Tehran and declared that “killing terrorists is good for America.”

Meanwhile, Israeli and U.S. strikes hit the Tehran building of a body tasked with electing Iran’s new supreme leader, local media reported.

“The American-Zionist criminals attacked the Assembly of Experts building in Qom,” south of Tehran, according to the Tasnim news agency. Local media showed footage of the building severely damaged in the strikes.

As the conflict in the region intensifies, Trump said that the US has “the capability to go far longer” than its projected four-to-five-week time frame for its military operations against Iran.

Across Tehran, the sound of explosions rang out through the night and into the early morning hours on Tuesday, as the US and Israel have continued to pound Iran since killing its Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei on Saturday.

Tehran and its allies have hit back against Israel, neighbouring Gulf states, and targets critical to the world’s production of oil and natural gas. The

intensity of the attacks and the lack of any apparent exit plan set the stage for a prolonged conflict with far-reaching consequences.

Israel and the US have given conflicting answers about what exactly the war’s objectives are or what the endgame might be.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu late Monday defended the decision to go to war, contending in an interview on Fox News that Iran was rebuilding “new sites, new places” that would make “their ballistic missile program and their atomic bomb program immune within months,” without providing evidence.

Satellite photos analysed by The Associated Press showed limited activity at two nuclear sites in Iran before the war, with analysts saying it was likely Tehran was trying to assess damage from American strikes in June and possibly salvage what remained there.

Call for putting an end to escalating violence and return to diplomacy was made by Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan.

“Our fundamental request and demand is clear: the mutual attacks must stop immediately, and diplomacy must resume,” Fidan said, according to a transcript of his remarks to journalists late Monday.

The Italian government said Tuesday it is working “non-stop” to assist Italian citizens stranded in the Middle East. Italy scheduled two flights, including one from Muscat, Oman, to Rome’s Fiumicino airport on Tuesday to carry around 300 people and another from Abu Dhabi to Milan to carry about 200 people, mostly

young students.

Romanian tourists arrived in Bucharest early Tuesday after travelling from Israel to Cairo to escape the conflict.

Hundreds of Romanian Orthodox Church pilgrims were stranded in Israel while visiting Bethlehem on a trip led by Romanian priests when the war broke out. The group was forced to cut their trip short to return to Romania.

Meanwhile, reports from Moscow said that Russian President Vladimir Putin is making all possible efforts to de-escalate the crisis in the Gulf and is in close contact with the regional leaders as Iran is retaliating with massive strikes on the US facilities and infrastructure on their territories.

“Putin will certainly make every effort to facilitate at least a minor easing of tensions. In this regard, we discussed with virtually all of our interlocutors yesterday,” the Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said.

“Taking advantage of the dialogue we maintain with the Iranian leadership, (President) Putin will convey his deep concern regarding the strikes on their infrastructure to our colleagues in Iran,” he added.

According to the Kremlin, Putin spoke by telephone with leaders of Bahrain, Qatar, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia.

In his telephonic conversation with Crown Prince and Chairman of the Council of Ministers of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, Mohammed bin Salman, Putin discussed the escalating situation in the region as a result of the American-Israeli armed aggression against Iran.

“Both sides expressed serious concern over the real risks of escalation of the conflict, which has already affected several Arab countries and is fraught with catastrophic consequences.

In this context, Vladimir Putin underscored the urgent need to resolve the current extremely dangerous situation through political and diplomatic means,” the Kremlin said.

Israel sent additional troops into southern Lebanon on Tuesday and ordered residents of more than 80 villages to evacuate as the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group said it is ready for an open war, escalating the already volatile situation in the region.

The latest exchanges started after Hezbollah fired rockets and drones early Monday toward northern Israel. Israel retaliated with a wave of airstrikes that killed 52 people in Lebanon, including a Palestinian militant and a Hezbollah intelligence official in Beirut’s southern suburbs.

More than 150 people were wounded and tens of thousands displaced.

Hezbollah said on Tuesday it fired two salvos of rockets toward northern Israel while Israeli airstrikes overnight damaged a building housing Hezbollah’s TV and radio stations. Beirut’s southern suburbs were subjected to a series of strikes in the afternoon on Tuesday that came without warning, and the Israeli military later said it targeted Hezbollah officials.

The Israeli military’s Arabic spokesman, Avichay Adraee, issued a warning for residents of more than 80 villages and

towns asking them to leave, adding that people should not return to these areas until further notice.

A senior Hezbollah official said that after more than a year of abiding by a ceasefire as Israel’s strikes continued on Lebanon, the group’s patience has ended, leaving it with no option “but to return to resistance” and fight an open war with Israel.

“The Zionist enemy wanted an open war, which it has not stopped since the ceasefire agreement,” Mohamoud Komati said “So let it be an open war.”

Lebanese President Joseph Aoun told the ambassadors of Saudi Arabia, Qatar, the US, France and Egypt that Hezbollah has been firing rockets from areas north of the Litani River.

The Lebanese government says it has disarmed Hezbollah south of the river, along the border with Israel, and Lebanese troops are in full control of the area between the river and the border.

The UN peacekeeping force in southern Lebanon, known as UNIFIL, said its peacekeepers observed Israeli forces crossing into Lebanon in several areas “before returning south of the Blue Line,” referring to the border between the two countries.

Israel launched a ground invasion of Lebanon in October 2024 during its last war with Hezbollah.

It withdrew from most of southern Lebanon after a US-brokered ceasefire halted the fighting in November 2024, but has continued to occupy five points on the Lebanese side of the border since then.

WITH AGENCY REPORTS

From Page 1

Nitin Nabin

Nabin’s predecessors — J P Nadda and Amit Shah — were also elected to the Upper House after they became the BJP chief.

The biennial polls to 37 Rajya Sabha seats across 10 states that are falling vacant on different dates in April are set to be held on March 16.

The counting of votes will take place the same day.

The states where the seats are falling vacant are Maharashtra (seven), Odisha (four), Telangana (two), Tamil Nadu (six), Chhattisgarh (two), West Bengal (five), Assam (three), Haryana (two), Himachal Pradesh (one) and Bihar (five).

The last date for filing nominations is March 5.

Fuel stocks

Last 25 days and fuel to last a similar duration, contingency plans - including using stockpile in strategic petroleum reserves, commercial stocks, and diversified sourcing from the US, Russia, West Africa, and Latin America - will ensure continuity even if the crisis lasts longer.

While immediate shortages are unlikely, rising crude prices and higher freight and insurance costs could impact India’s import bill and inflation.

Separately, the ministry in a statement said Oil Minister Hard-eep Singh Puri “briefed the media on the country’s preparedness in the current circumstances” and it was informed that “the country is well stocked with crude oil and inventories of key petroleum products including petrol, diesel and ATF to deal with short-term disruptions arising from the Middle East.”

It, however, did not give details of the stocks.

“The Ministry has established a 24x7 control room to continuously monitor the supply and stock position of petroleum products across the country,” it said.

“At present, the government is reasonably comfortable in terms of stocks. Safeguarding the interests of Indian consumers remains the highest priority. Based on continuous monitoring, the government is cautiously optimistic that phased measures can be taken, if required, to further mitigate the situation.”

India is the third largest importer, fourth largest refiner, and fifth largest exporter of petroleum products globally.

“It was further apprised that in the last few years, India has ensured both availability and affordability of energy for its pop-

ulation by diversifying its sources. Indian energy companies now have access to energy supplies that are not routed through the Strait of Hormuz.

“Such cargoes will remain available and help mitigate supplies that may be temporarily affected enroute through the Strait of Hormuz,” the statement said.

The official said that while this year crude sourced from the countries that use the Strait of Hormuz is above 50 per cent due to a drop in Russian cargoes, the average over the past couple of years has been 40 per cent. The remaining 60 per cent is not shipped from the Strait.

Crude oil -- the raw material that is turned into fuels like petrol and diesel in refineries -- in storage tanks, pipelines and on ships in transit is enough to meet the country’s requirement for 25 days. Besides, there are stock of fuel in refineries, deposits, pipelines and other storage facilities that could meet demand for a similar duration, he said.

On top of this, there is crude oil stored in underground strategic reserves.

The country’s commercial crude oil stocks, including strategic petroleum reserves at Mangalore, Padur, and Visakhapatnam, total around 100 million barrels. This, along with additional refined product inventories, provides a substantial buffer against short-term disruptions.

“We are in a reasonably comfortable situation,” the official said.

The official said India was looking to import LPG even before the Iran crisis broke out last weekend.

An issue with the pipeline in Saudi Arabia, the principal supplier of LPG to India, had created a deficit of 120,000 tonnes.

“There are a large number of producers, and we are tapping them,” the official said.

With imports via the Strait of Hormuz averaging roughly 2.5 million barrels per day -- about half of India’s just over 5 million bpd total crude imports -- these combined reserves could theoretically cover around 40-45 days of imports in a crude disruption scenario, he said.

Additional refined product inventories would extend effective coverage further.

However, the immediate impact will be on prices. Brent, the global benchmark, crossed USD 80 per barrel, roughly 10 per cent more since the Iran crisis. For India, higher prices means higher import bill.

India spent USD 137 billion on crude oil imports in the fiscal year ended March 31, 2025. During April 2025 to January 2026 - the first ten months of the current fiscal year - it spent USD 100.4 billion on imports of 206.3 million tonnes of crude oil.

The United States and Israel launched military strikes on targets in Iran over the week-

end. Tehran retaliated with missiles and drones aimed at Israel and countries hosting US forces, including the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Kuwait, Bahrain, Iraq, Jordan and Saudi Arabia.

Media reports suggest the conflict has effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz, a key conduit for global energy flows. Roughly one-third of the world’s seaborne crude oil exports and about 20 per cent of liquefied natural gas shipments transit the narrow waterway.

India, the world’s third-largest oil importer, imports roughly half of its crude needs through the narrow Strait. Its mainstay liquefied natural gas (LNG) supplier in Qatar also uses the strait to ship the fuel to India.

In case of closure, India can tap suppliers in West Africa, Latin America and the US to make up for the shortfall from the Middle-East. India could also tap Russian oil to make up for the deficit.

India had agreed to wind down purchases of Russian oil as part of a trade deal with the US - a deal which now sits in limbo after the US Supreme Court struck down US President Donald Trump’s country-based tariffs.

Tehran

stay where you are, remain indoors as far as possible, and stay away from windows,” the embassy said.

In the fresh advisory, the embassy also urged the Indians to exercise caution at all times, avoid visiting areas of protests or demonstrations and remain in regular contact with the mission.

Around 9,000 Indians including students are learnt to be stuck in Iran. The exact number of Indian students in Iran is not immediately known.

The conflict in West Asia intensified with Iran carrying out fresh strikes targeting Israel and American military bases in the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, Bahrain and Saudi Arabia after the US and Israel attacked Iran on Saturday.

As part of its offensive, Iran has blocked the strategically located strait of Hormuz shipping route triggering surge in global oil prices.

The US military has said six of its personnel were killed in the conflict so far.

The US-Israeli strikes have killed at least 787 people, the Iranian Red Crescent Society said. At least 11 people were killed in Israel, according to reports. MPOST

Texas shooting

mass shooting in down-

town Austin. The killing has sent shockwaves through Austin’s sizable Indian diaspora, particularly among students and technology professionals in the city’s “Silicon Hills” corridor.

Heightened security concerns have emerged across the country after attacks on Iran this weekend by the United States and Israel, and retaliation by Iran.

A spokesman for the University of Texas at Austin confirmed Shan was a student at the school and said her legal last name was Shanmugasundaram, according to school records, the New York Times reported.

The university’s president, Jim Davis, described her in a letter to campus as “a child of loving parents. A loyal friend to many. A Longhorn preparing to change the world.”

Shan was a graduate of the Liberal Arts and Science Academy and was widely regarded as a high-achieving and community-oriented student.

Federal authorities, led by the FBI Joint Terrorism Task Force, are investigating the attack for possible international or ideological links.

The suspect, identified as 53-year-old Ndiaga Diagne, a naturalised US citizen originally from Senegal, was killed by police at the scene.

Investigators said materials recovered from the scene and the suspect’s residence included an Iranian flag and extremist writings, prompting authorities to examine the possibility of self-radicalised terrorism.

The shooting occurred around 1:59 am at Buford’s Backyard Beer Garden. Witnesses told police the suspect first fired from an SUV before exiting the vehicle with a rifle. Austin Police said officers neutralised the gunman within about a minute of the first emergency call.

Four people have been killed, including the suspect. Fourteen others were injured, several of them students, with at least three reported in critical condition.

One of the injured, Karan Bhakta, a 21-year-old senior at the University of Texas, said he had been enjoying a night out with friends when a bullet grazed his scalp, the report added.

On Monday morning, the University of Texas campus was quiet, despite student body elections beginning this week. The few students who were out said the shooting had sparked new fears about gun violence.

Indian-American community leaders in Austin said they are coordinating with local authorities to support the Shan family and other affected residents.

Plans are underway for a community memorial service as the investigation into the motive continues.

Assam polls

According to the list of candidates released by All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary, organisation, K C Venugopal, Abhusobhan Ali Sarkar has been fielded from Gauripur, Markline Marak from Goalpara West (reserved for Scheduled Tribe candidates), Girish Baruah from Bongaigaon and Mahananda Sarkar from Barpeta (reserved for Scheduled Caste candidates).

Ramen Singh Rabha will be the party candidate from the Boko-Chaygaon (ST) seat, Nandita Das from Hajo-Sualkuchi (SC) and Satyabrata Kalita from Kamalpur.

Mira Borthakur Goswami has been fielded from Dispur, while Diganta Barman will be the party candidate from Barkhetri and Ashok Kumar Sarma from Nalbari.

The polls for the 126-member Assam Assembly are likely to be held in April.

The Congress has been out of power in the northeastern state since 2016.

Sonia

UAE without addressing the sequence of events that preceded it. Later, he uttered platitudes about his ‘deep concern’ and talked of ‘dialogue and diplomacy’ -- which is precisely what was underway before the massive unprovoked attacks launched by Israel and the US,” Gandhi said.

“When the targeted killing of a foreign leader draws no clear defence of sovereignty or international law from our country and impartiality is abandoned, it raises serious doubts about the direction and credibility of our foreign policy,” Gandhi said in her article.

Silence, in this instance, is not neutral, she asserted.

Gandhi pointed out that the assassination was carried out without a formal declaration of war and during an ongoing diplomatic process.

“Article 2 (4) of the United Nations Charter prohibits the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any state. A targeted killing of a serving head of state strikes at the heart of these principles,” she said.

If such acts pass without principled objection from the world’s largest democracy, the erosion of international norms becomes easier to normalise, she argued.

“The unease is compounded by the timing. Barely 48 hours before the assassination, the Prime Minister returned from a visit to Israel, where he reiterated unequivocal support for the government of Benjamin Netanyahu, even as the Gaza conflict contin-

ues to draw global outrage over the scale of civilian casualties, many of them women and children,” Gandhi said.

At a time when much of the Global South, along with major powers and India’s partners in BRICS such as Russia and China, have kept their distance, India’s high-profile political endorsement without moral clarity marks a visible and troubling departure, she said.

“The consequences of this event extend beyond geopolitics. The ripples of this tragedy are visible across continents. And India’s stance is signalling tacit endorsement of this tragedy,” she claimed.

Gandhi pointed out that the Congress has unequivocally condemned the bombings and targeted assassinations on Iranian soil, describing them as a dangerous escalation with grave regional and global consequences.

“We have extended condolences to the Iranian people and to Shia communities worldwide, reiterating that India’s foreign policy is anchored in the peaceful settlement of disputes, as reflected in Article 51 of the Constitution of India. These principles ‘sovereign equality, non-intervention and the promotion of peace’ have historically been integral to India’s diplomatic identity. The present reticence, therefore, appears not merely tactical, but discordant with our stated principles,” she said.

The present government would do well to remember that in April 2001, the then prime minister, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, during an official visit to Tehran, warmly reaffirmed India’s deep ties with Iran, both civilisational and contemporary, Gandhi said.

“His (Vajpayee’s) acknowledgement of those long-standing relations seems to hold no relevance for our current government,” she said.

She further asked as to why should countries in the Global South trust India to defend their territorial integrity tomorrow if it appears hesitant to defend that principle today.

“The appropriate forum for resolving this dissonance is Parliament. When it reconvenes, this disturbing silence over the breakdown of international order must be debated openly and without evasion,” Gandhi said.

The targeted killing of a foreign head of state, the erosion of international norms, and the widening instability in West Asia are not peripheral matters; they touch directly upon India’s strategic interests and moral commitments, she asserted.

“A clear articulation of India’s position is overdue. Democratic accountability demands no less, and strategic clarity requires it,” Gandhi said.

“India has long invoked the ideal of vasudhaiva kutumbakam ‘the world is one family. That civilisational ethos is not a slo-

gan for ceremonial diplomacy; it implies a commitment to justice, restraint and dialogue, even when doing so is inconvenient.

“At moments when the rules-based order is under visible strain, silence is abdication,” Gandhi said.

India has long-aspired to be more than a regional power and it has sought to serve as the conscience-keeper of the world, she said.

That stature was built on a willingness to speak for sovereignty, peace, non-violence and justice even when doing so was inconvenient, she said.

“At this moment, there is an urgent need for us to rediscover that moral strength and articulate it with clarity and commitment,” Gandhi said.

Khamenei was killed in a major attack by Israel and the US in the early hours of Saturday.

The United States and Israel launched a major attack on Iran on Saturday, with US President Donald Trump calling on the Iranian public to seize control of their destiny and rise against the Islamic leadership that has ruled their country since 1979.

PM Modi

As India emerges as a beacon of hope for the world thanks to its robust economy, and as global supply chains undergo transformation, the prime minister said, rapid economic development has become the cornerstone for realising the vision of Viksit Bharat.

The goal of a developed India can only be achieved through collective ownership, he said, adding, “The budget has provided the framework; now you must generate momentum together.”

Stressing that manufacturing, logistics, MSMEs, small and cottage industries, and even small and large cities appear as separate pillars of the economy, he said they are all interconnected.

“Strong manufacturing creates new opportunities and boosts exports. Competitive MSMEs promote flexibility and innovation. Better logistics reduce costs. Well-planned cities attract both investment and talent. This year’s budget has strengthened all these pillars significantly,” he said.

Now is the time for MSMEs to increase productivity, raise quality standards, adopt digital processes, and integrate into strong value chains.

Your suggestions in this direction will be extremely important, he added.

Highlighting the importance of infrastructure and logistics, he said, they serve as fundamental pillars of our growth strategy.

In the manufacturing sector, he said, India is strengthening its core industrial capabilities while addressing existing challenges.

WEST ASIA CONFLICT

Didn't feel any relief until finally landed in India: Stranded passengers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI/ BENGALURU: Whether in transit or on a trip to Dubai, fliers who returned to India after being stranded in the conflict-hit region narrated their ordeal, from hearing sounds of explosions to experiencing financial woes, long waits and confusion during their stay there.

Several passengers said they heaved a sigh of relief only when their aircraft touched the Indian soil after a long and arduous journey, and thanked the central and the respective state governments for the arrangements.

Lok Sabha BJP MP from Chandni Chowk in Delhi, Praveen Khandelwal, on Tuesday said his daughter, who was stranded in Dubai for the last three days amid the ongoing conflict between Israel and Iran, returned safely to India. He said she had travelled to Dubai on a business trip and was unable to return due to flight cancellations.

Tensions have escalated following a coordinated offensive launched by the United States and Israel against Iran on February 28. The US and Israel jointly launched military strikes on the Islamic country on Saturday. Iran responded by firing drones and missiles at Israel and US military installations across the Gulf, and also at the global business hub of Dubai.

"I didn't feel any relief, not even during the flight, until I finally landed in Delhi," said Sunil Gupta, one of the several passengers who returned home shaken.

Gupta, who was returning from Dubai, said the uncertainty was overwhelming.



An Indian who was stranded in the Middle East due to flight disruptions seeks blessings from his family members upon arrival at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport, in Mumbai, Tuesday

HIGHLIGHTS

» Several passengers said they heaved a sigh of relief only when their aircraft touched the Indian soil

» 'People had just gone there for a few days and are not able to handle the expenses'

Arvind, a resident of Noida who also returned from Dubai, said many people were stranded after flights got cancelled.

"People had just gone there for a few days and are not able to handle the expenses. The stranded tourists are facing a serious financial burden. That is the biggest problem right now," he said.

He said the flight that he had initially booked was cancelled, forcing him to stay back for four extra days.

"During that time, we kept hearing about and seeing incidents around us. I personally saw explosions in the sky, but they (missiles) were being intercepted. Even though the

missiles were intercepted, witnessing something like that creates fear," he said.

For some families, the distress has been far more personal. Kunwar Shakeel Ahmed, father of an Indian student studying in Iran, said the situation near his daughter's hostel is frightening.

"Sounds of blasts can be heard. Whatever missiles are being fired are landing very close to where they are staying. She told me that after one blast nearby, parts of the roof and the plaster of the hostel building fell off. You can imagine what the girls must be going through," Ahmed said.

Another passenger, Suhail Ahmed, returning from Muscat, said delays and uncertainty at airports worsened the situation.

"There were long waits and confusion. Families with children were struggling and many people were running short of money. In such times, authorities should ensure a faster clearance and better arrangements for those trying to return," he added.

PM Modi speaks to Sultan of Oman, Crown Prince of Kuwait and Amir of Qatar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to Sultan Haitham bin Tarik of Oman, Crown Prince of Kuwait Sheikh Sabah Al-Khaled Al-Hamad Al-Mubarak Al-Sabah and Amir of Qatar Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani on Tuesday, and expressed concern over attacks on their countries during the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

During his telephonic conversations, Modi also condemned the violation of the three countries' sovereignty and territorial integrity and discussed with the leaders the welfare and security of the Indian community residing there.

Over the last two days, the Prime Minister has spoken to the leaders of eight West Asian countries, in the wake of a coordinated offensive launched against Iran by the United States and Israel, in which the Islamic country's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, was killed.



PM Narendra Modi

In retaliation, Iran has fired drones and missiles at Israel and US military installations around the Gulf, as also at the global business and aviation hubs of Dubai and Doha.

Modi said he has spoken to Sultan Haitham bin Tarik of Oman and exchanged views on recent developments in West Asia.

"Condemned the violation of Oman's sovereignty and territorial integrity. We agreed that sustained diplomatic engagement is essential for earliest restoration of regional peace and stability. Deeply appreciated Oman's continued support to

Over the last two days, the Prime Minister has spoken to the leaders of eight West Asian countries

the Indian community," he said in a post on X.

During Modi's talks with the Crown Prince of Kuwait, the two leaders underscored the significance of dialogue and diplomacy in restoring regional peace and stability.

"Had a productive telephone conversation with Crown Prince of Kuwait, HH Sheikh Sabah Al-Khaled Al-Hamad Al-Mubarak Al-Sabah. India condemns violation of Kuwait's sovereignty and territorial integrity and stands with its people in this difficult hour," the prime minister said.

He appreciated the Kuwaiti

leadership's continued support to ensure the safety and well-being of the Indian community in that country.

During Modi's talks with the Amir of Qatar, both leaders emphasised the urgent need to restore peace and stability in the region through dialogue and diplomacy.

"Spoke with my brother, HH Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, the Amir of Qatar. We stand firmly in solidarity with Qatar and strongly condemn any violation of its sovereignty and territorial integrity," Modi said.

The PM also conveyed his appreciation for the Amir's continued support and care for the Indian community in Qatar during this challenging time.

Over the last two days, Modi has spoken to the King of Bahrain and the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, and condemned attacks on the two countries, asserting that India stands in solidarity with their people in this difficult hour.

CBSE postpones board exams scheduled on March 5, 6 in Middle East

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Tuesday postponed the class 10 and 12 board exams scheduled for March 5 and 6 in the Middle East region amid the Iran-Israel conflict, officials said.

"Due to the current situation in parts of the Middle East---Bahrain, Iran, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and UAE, the board has decided to postpone class 10, 12 exams on March 5 (Thursday) and March 6 (Friday)," said CBSE Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj.

The new dates will be announced later, and for further exams, the situation will be reviewed on March 5, Bhardwaj added.

On Sunday, the board had postponed the exam scheduled on March 2 in the region.

Punjab minister seeks immediate launch of rescue flights for Punjabis

NEW DELHI: Punjab's NRI Affairs minister Ravjot Singh met Union Civil Aviation minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu on Tuesday and demanded the immediate launch of rescue flights for the state's people stranded in West Asia in large numbers due to the escalating conflict in the region.

He also demanded operation of special flights to the region and a cap on "exploitative" airfares.

The Civil Aviation Ministry on Monday said that Indian airlines cancelled 357 international flights during the day as disruptions continued



for the third consecutive day. More than 1,100 international flights have been cancelled by Indian carriers since February 28 due to the situation.

Against the backdrop of the situation, Singh said, "There is an urgent need to resume flights and operate special evacuation services. Our people cannot be left stranded in this crisis." MPOST

Nitish agrees to let son Nishant enter politics; Rajya Sabha not ruled out

PATNA: Eschewing aversion for "dynasty politics", Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on Tuesday agreed to launch his only son Nishant in politics, a development that led to jubilations in the JD(U) and triggered speculation of a Rajya Sabha berth for the scion.

The announcement came from state Rural Development Minister and senior party leader Shrawon Kumar, who has been a close aide of the JD(U) supremo since the Samata Party days, in the 1990s.

"On the eve of Holi, I have some good news to share with the people of Bihar. It has been some time since there have been demands, from within the



Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar with his son Nishant Kumar at his official residence, in Patna

JD(U) as well as from among the state's youth, that Nishant, the son of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, join politics. Decks have been cleared for that and a formal announcement will be made in a day or two," Shrawon

Kumar told news agency.

When he was asked whether the JD(U) supremo's son, an engineering graduate who is in his 40s, could be one of the two party candidates for the biennial Rajya Sabha elections, the JD(U) leader replied, "Anything is possible. All would be made known in a day or two after top party leaders sit down to discuss these things."

As soon as the news spread, celebrations erupted at the JD(U)'s state headquarters here, the walls of which have for some time been adorned with posters demanding that the supreme leader's son take over the reins from his father. MPOST

Government of Haryana

Heartiest Greetings on the festival of colours

Holi

March 4 , 2026

"Happy Holi to all of you. May this auspicious festival, filled with joy and happiness, infuse everyone's life with new enthusiasm and energy, and deepen the spirit of unity among our countrymen."

-Narendra Modi

Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

www.prharyana.gov.in

Follow us on [Facebook] [Twitter] [Instagram] [YouTube] [LinkedIn] [WhatsApp] [Telegram] [Email]

@dipraryana

DEFENCE MINISTRY SEALS CONTRACT FOR ACQUISITION OF 6 CHOPPERS

Over Rs 5K crore boost for Navy, Coast Guard

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Defence Ministry on Tuesday signed contracts worth Rs 5,083 crore for the procurement of six Advanced Light Helicopters (ALH) for the Indian Coast Guard and surface-to-air missiles for the Indian Navy, in a move aimed at strengthening maritime security and air defence capabilities.

Of the total outlay, Rs 2,901 crore has been earmarked for the acquisition of ALH Mk-III helicopters in the maritime role from Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL). The agreement includes the supply of operational role equipment, an engineering support package, and performance-based logistics support to ensure sustained operational readiness.

The twin-engine helicopters are equipped with advanced avionics and surveillance systems and are designed to undertake a wide range of maritime missions. These include coastal surveillance, search and rescue, medical evacuation, anti-smuggling operations and protection of offshore assets. The



Officials during the signing of defence contracts on Tuesday

PTI

aircraft can operate both from shore-based airfields and from ships at sea, enhancing operational flexibility.

According to the ministry, the induction of the ALH Mk-III will significantly boost the Indian Coast Guard's capacity to safeguard artificial islands, offshore installations and critical maritime infrastructure. It will also strengthen efforts to ensure the safety of fishermen and protect the marine environment, particularly in India's vast exclusive economic zone.

In a parallel development,

the ministry signed a Rs 2,182 crore contract with Russia's JSC Rosoboronexport for the procurement of surface-to-air vertical launch Shtil missile systems along with associated missile holding frames. These systems are intended for deployment on frontline warships of the Indian Navy.

The Shtil missile system is designed to provide area air defence against a broad spectrum of aerial threats, including aircraft, helicopters, anti-ship missiles and unmanned aerial vehicles. With rapid-reaction

Highlights

» It said these twin-engine helicopters incorporate state-of-the-art features superior to the currently operated airborne platforms

» The contract for the procurement of surface-to-air vertical launch - Shtil missiles and associated missile holding frames, valued at Rs 2,182 crore, has been signed with Russia's JSC Rosoboronexport

» The acquisition is intended to substantially enhance the air defence capabilities of frontline warships against a wide spectrum of aerial threats, the ministry said

capability and all-weather operational readiness, the system is expected to enhance the survivability of naval platforms operating in high-threat maritime environments.

The Defence Ministry said the acquisition would reinforce the Navy's layered air defence architecture by adding a robust medium-range engagement capability. This layered approach integrates multiple defensive systems to intercept threats at varying distances, thereby improving overall fleet protection.

The signing of the missile contract also highlights the continuing defence coopera-

tion between India and Russia. The ministry described the partnership as longstanding and founded on mutual trust and strategic alignment, with defence ties remaining a key pillar of bilateral relations.

Together, the helicopter and missile procurements reflect the government's continued focus on modernising maritime forces amid evolving security challenges in the Indian Ocean region. The contracts are expected to contribute not only to operational capability but also to sustained defence preparedness across multiple maritime domains.

Safety of 1 crore Indians top priority: India amid Iran conflict

Calls for 'dialogue and diplomacy' to end the conflict

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As the conflict in West Asia intensified, India on Tuesday emphasised the interest of one crore Indian nationals in the region and voiced concern over possible disruptions in energy supplies because it could have serious consequences for the Indian economy.

New Delhi also strongly called for "dialogue and diplomacy" to ensure an early end to the conflict, while noting that India has critical stakes in the security and stability of the region as a proximate neighbour and the current developments "evoke great anxiety".

In its second statement since the US and Israel attacked Iran and Tehran's subsequent retaliation, India said the safety and security of Indians living in West Asia is its "utmost priority".

"In recent days, we have not only witnessed an intensification of the conflict but also its spread to other nations. The destruction and deaths have mounted,

Takeaways

» The MEA, however, did not mention the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in the US-Israeli strike

» The MEA said that already, some Indian nationals have lost their lives or are missing as a result of the attacks in the last few days

even as normal life and economic activities come to a halt," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said.

"As a proximate neighbour with critical stakes in the security and stability of the region, these developments evoke great anxiety," it said.

The MEA, however, did not mention the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in the US-Israeli strike.

"There are almost one

crore Indian citizens who live and work in the Gulf region. Their safety and well-being is of utmost priority. We cannot be impervious to any development that negatively affects them," it said.

"Our trade and energy supply chains also traverse this geography. Any major disruption has serious consequences for the Indian economy."

"As a country whose nationals are prominent in the global workforce, India is also firmly opposed to attacks on merchant shipping," it said.

The MEA said that already, some Indian nationals have lost their lives or are missing as a result of the attacks in the last few days.

"In this background, India strongly reiterates its call for dialogue and diplomacy. We raise our voice clearly in favour of an early end to the conflict. Already, many lives have been regrettably lost and we express our grief in that regard," the MEA said.

Mosques covered, heavy security in UP ahead of Holi

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Authorities across several districts in Uttar Pradesh have stepped up security arrangements ahead of Holi, which will be celebrated on Wednesday, with administrations covering mosques along procession routes and deploying heavy police forces to ensure the festival passes peacefully.

In districts such as Shahjahanpur, Sambhal, Bijnor and Dhampur town, mosques situated along traditional Holi procession routes have been covered with large tarpaulin sheets. Officials described the move as a precautionary mea-

In Shahjahanpur, around 92 mosques and shrines have been covered

sure to protect religious structures from colour and gugal and to prevent any untoward incident that could disturb communal harmony.

In Shahjahanpur, around 92 mosques and shrines falling along the route of the popular "Laat Saheb" or "Juta Maar" Holi procession have been covered. Police and administrative officials said the exercise began several days in advance.

Apart from religious sites, electricity transformers along the route have also been covered and plastic sheets tied around poles as part of safety measures.

In Sambhal, nearly 10 mosques, including the historic Shahi Jama Masjid, have been fully covered with tarpaulins. Two separate Holi processions are scheduled to pass in front of the mosque. Officials said the decision was taken in view of an incident in the past when splashes of colour accidentally fell on a mosque, triggering tension in the area. Sambhal District Magistrate Rajender Pensiya said covering mosques during Holi has become a customary practice.

VALMIKI NAIK

NEW DELHI: The 2004 US presidential election unfolded in the long shadow of the 9/11 attacks, becoming a high-stakes referendum on leadership in a transformed global order.

The incumbent, George W. Bush, faced criticism over the invasion of Iraq, launched on the claim that Saddam Hussein possessed weapons of mass destruction — weapons that were never found. His Democratic challenger, John Kerry, was an experienced legislator and a decorated Vietnam War veteran. Kerry had served as commander of a U.S. Navy Swift boat in Vietnam's riverine operations and had received



multiple gallantry medals. The contrast with Bush — whose Vietnam-era National Guard service had long drawn scrutiny — was politically stark.

As the race tightened, a group calling itself Swift Boat Veterans for Truth launched a campaign challenging Kerry's military record. Through tele-

vision advertisements, press conferences, talk radio and a book titled Unfit for Command, the group cast doubt on his wartime service and medals. The attacks, amplified by partisan media and emerging online platforms, forced Kerry to spend crucial weeks defending his record rather than advancing his policy agenda.

Though Bush ultimately won re-election by a narrow margin, the episode left behind a new political term: "swift-boating" — the tactic of attacking an opponent's strongest credential through sustained, often controversial or unverified claims, in order to erode public trust.

Two decades later, critics of

the Indian government argue that a similar strategy has been deployed against Arvind Kejriwal. Kejriwal built his public persona around anti-corruption activism.

Supporters contend that the so-called Delhi excise policy case — widely referred to as the "Delhi Liquor Scam" in political discourse — represents an effort to politically neutralize him and destabilize his party.

They argue that by targeting senior AAP leaders through investigations and arrests, the objective was to weaken the party's leadership structure ahead of elections.

(The writer is the state president of Aam Aadmi Party's Goa unit)

Set up 24x7 NRI control room to assist families of stranded Punjabis: Punjab CM

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Tuesday called on Union Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu and impressed upon him to ensure the safe evacuation of Punjabis stranded in the strife-torn Middle East.

During the telephonic conversation, the CM shared comprehensive data pertaining to Punjabis languishing in Gulf countries due to the sudden outbreak of war and urged that immediate steps be taken to bring them home.

Taking to X, CM Mann stated: "I spoke over the phone with Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu. NRI Affairs

Punjab govt shares list of stranded persons with Centre

Minister Dr. Ravjot Singh had also gone to meet him in person. The Union Minister has assured that necessary arrangements will be made for the safe return of Punjabis from Arab countries, including the operation of special flights. I have shared the list of all concerned persons along with their contact numbers. Soon, these Punjabis will return safely to their families. For any kind of information or assistance, please contact: NRI Wing 24/7 Control Room: *0172-2260042*, *0172-2260043*, WhatsApp: *+91 94787 79112*."

Reiterating the firm commitment of the Punjab government to evacuate Punjabis stuck in the strife-torn Middle East, the CM asserted: "Punjabis have played a stellar role in making the country self-reliant in food production and in safeguarding the unity, integrity and sovereignty of the country. It is unfortunate that a large number of Punjabis are stuck across the Middle East due to the sudden eruption of war. The Union Government must arrange special aircraft carriers to bring the stranded Punjabis back."

"Cabinet Minister Ravjot has been deputed to meet Union Civil Aviation Minister Naidu," he added.

Hry CM releases over Rs 60K cr for 602 gaushalas

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini released Rs 68.34 crore fodder grant for the empowerment of gaushalas in the state at a State-Level Gaushala Fodder Grant Distribution programme held in village Bhatgaon, Sonipat. On the occasion, he also extended greetings to the people of the state on the festival of Holi.

Addressing the gathering, the CM said that cows are a symbol of our culture and faith. He said that Gau Seva is not merely a religious activity, but is also linked to social harmony, rural economy and environmental protection. He also announced Rs.21 lakh each for both Gram Panchayats of Bhatgaon and Dharmarth Gaushala Bhatgaon.

The CM said that Rs. 5.60 crore has been released for 27 registered gaushalas in Sonipat district. At present, 602 registered gaushalas in the state are receiving this grant, ensuring proper fodder arrangements for thousands of Gauvansh sheltered there.

He shared that in the past over eleven years, the state government had provided Rs. 457.41 crore to registered gaushalas. With the present release, the total grant amount has increased to more than Rs.525.75 crore, reflecting the government's commitment to cow protection.

The CM said that in 2014, there were only 215 registered gaushalas in the state, caring for 1.75 lakh Gauvansh. Currently, 697 registered gaushalas are operational.

AHEAD OF 2027 UP POLLS

SP to use Kanshi Ram legacy to woo dalits

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Samajwadi Party has decided to celebrate the birth anniversary of Bahujan Samaj Party founder Kanshi Ram across all districts of Uttar Pradesh on March 15 in a bid to reach out to Dalit voters.

The party has decided to observe his birth anniversary across districts and project it as a day dedicated to its PDA plank of Dalits, backward classes and minorities. Senior leaders say the move is aimed at reviving memories of the 1990s social coalition between Kanshi Ram and Samajwadi Party founder Mulayam Singh Yadav, which had altered the political balance in the state. By invoking that phase, the Samajwadi



Akhilesh Yadav has directed office bearers to organise events on Kanshi Ram Jayanti

Prof Ravi, a retired teacher from Jawaharlal Nehru University and a keen observer of contemporary politics, said the Mulayam-Kanshi Ram factor once had a significant impact in Uttar Pradesh. He said that in the 1990s, this alliance brought about a major shift in the social and political standing of Dalits and Other Backward Classes.

The Samajwadi Party leadership believes that reviving the Dalit and backward class alli-

ance can strengthen its position in the state. The party is banking on its PDA formula, referring to Dalits, backward classes and minorities, to return to power. As part of this outreach, Kanshi Ram Jayanti will be observed as PDA Diwas.

Through district level events, the party will also remind people that Kanshi Ram had led a nationwide movement in support of the Mandal Commission report and had intensified the Bahujan movement after reaching an understanding with Mulayam Singh Yadav in 1992. Party leaders will also highlight that it was Kanshi Ram's support that helped Mulayam Singh form the government in December 1993.

Snakebite poisoning declared notifiable disease in Himachal

SHIMLA: The Himachal Pradesh government has declared snakebite envenomation (poisoning) a notifiable disease in the state in consonance with the National Action Plan for Prevention and Control of Snakebite Envenoming (NAPSE) in India by 2030, a statement issued here on Tuesday said.

A state government notification issued last week by the secretary, health and family welfare, directed all health facilities -- both public and private -- and medical practitioners to report all suspected snakebite cases and deaths to the respective public health authority. This will help in tracking snakebite incidents, identify high-risk areas for deploying resources like anti-snake venom and factors for deaths of snakebite victims, resulting in improved clinical management of snakebite cases, the notification said.

Member of a World Health Organization (WHO) expert panel on snakebite poisoning, Dr Omesh Bharti -- also member of the national task force on prevention and control of snakebites -- on Tuesday said the notification mandating

According to an estimate, around 100 deaths occur due to snakebites in Himachal every year

snakebite cases and deaths is a significant step towards prevention and control of snakebite poisoning in the state.

Snakebite has been a neglected tropical disease and claims around 50,000 lives in India annually due to persistent gaps in management of snakebites, socially and medically.

According to an estimate, around 100 deaths occur due to snakebites in Himachal every year.

Although health authorities claim that snakebite deaths have come down drastically in India as per a new survey of 13 states across the country including Himachal Pradesh, snakebites still remain a challenge in the rural parts of the state. Most of the people bitten by snakes prefer going to traditional 'healers', delaying medical care, thus resulting in aggravation of the patient's condition.

'Nearly 500% increase in breast cancer cases in India since 1990'

352% increase in deaths between 1990 and 2023

NEW DELHI: A new study has found breast cancer to be a leading cause of mortality and morbidity in women worldwide, with India registering a staggering 477 per cent increase in breast cancer cases and 352 per cent increase in deaths caused by the disease between 1990 and 2023.

The study published in the Lancet Oncology estimated the number of breast cancer cases globally to rise to 3.5 million by 2050 -- rising by a third from 2.3 million in 2023 -- and deaths to increase by 44 per cent to about 1.37 million yearly.

According to the study, led by Kayleigh Bhangdia from the Institute for Health Metrics and Evaluation (IHME), University of Washington, US, India registered about 2.03 lakh cancer cases in 2023, nearly 477 per cent increase from 2023, and over one lakh deaths, a 352.3 per cent increase, since 1990.

The impact of the disease was not standard across the globe, with low- and middle-income nations being more

INSIGHT

» The impact of the disease was not standard across the globe, with low- and middle-income nations being more affected than the high-income group

» The study noted that the age-standardised incidence rate (ASIR)



increased by 147.2 per cent in the low-income group compared with only 1.2 per cent change in the high-income group.

affected than the high-income group. The study noted that the age-standardised incidence rate (ASIR) increased by 147.2 per cent in the low-income group compared with only 1.2 per cent change in the high-income group.

The age-standardised mortality rate (ASMR) decreased in the high-income group, changing by a negative 29.9 per cent, but increased by 99.3 per cent in the low-income group.

"Breast cancer continues to take a profound toll on women's lives and communities... While those in high-income

countries typically benefit from screening and more timely diagnosis and comprehensive treatment strategies, the mounting burden of breast cancer is shifting to low- and lower middle-income countries where individuals often face later-stage diagnosis, more limited access to quality care, and higher death rates that are threatening to eclipse progress in women's health," Bhangdia said. The study credits stable incidence and declining mortality rates in high-income nations to success in screening, diagnosis.

Nation Briefs

COP INJURED AS CAR RAMS HIS BIKE, DRAGS IT FOR 5 KM IN UP'S MAU

MAU: A police constable was injured after a car allegedly rammed his motorcycle here and dragged it for nearly 5 km while attempting to flee, officials said on Tuesday. Police have seized the vehicle and launched raids to apprehend the absconding driver, they said. The incident took place within the city limits, with the constable's motorcycle dragged from the Kotwali police station area to the Dakshin Tola police station area, causing panic among residents, officials said. A purported CCTV footage of the incident has been released by the police.

TWO HACKED TO DEATH, FIVE INJURED IN TN'S TIRUNELVELI

TIRUNELVELI: Two persons, including a migrant worker from Odisha, were allegedly hacked to death by a nine-member gang in Nanguneri, police said. Five people sustained injuries in this attack, they added. The deceased were identified as John Mark (47), a resident of Perumalpattu village, and 57-year-old Srinath Gadda from Odisha. Top government sources said 'some of the assailants' were traced and arrested later in the day. Those who sustained injuries and were admitted to the district government hospital are A Nelson, P Prabhakaran, V Ramaswamy, A Ganesan and S Sasikumar.



EDITORIAL
MANAGING
UNWANTED
FALLOUT

Europe did not plan for this war, but it is now living with its consequences. The widening confrontation between the United States and Israel on one side and Iran on the other has pulled the continent into a crisis it neither initiated nor endorsed. Tehran's retaliatory strikes across the Middle East have forced European governments into urgent defensive measures — protecting bases, reinforcing domestic security and scrambling to evacuate citizens stranded in a rapidly closing theatre of conflict. The Middle East is not a distant battleground for Europe. It is a region interwoven with European trade, energy flows and human connections. From Beirut to Dubai to Jerusalem, tens of thousands of Europeans live and work. At home, large diaspora communities from Turkey, Egypt and the Gulf states bind the two regions together socially and economically. Yet European capitals were not consulted before this military escalation began. They are now dealing with its fallout.

Officially, Britain, France and Germany have stopped short of joining the war. In practice, however, the line is thinner. London has indicated that US forces may use British bases to target Iranian missile infrastructure. European leaders speak of helping Washington defend against Iranian retaliation, even as they insist they are not belligerents. The contradiction reflects Europe's strategic bind: dependent on American security guarantees but wary of uncontrolled escalation. The shock reached European soil when a Shahed-type drone damaged a British air base in Cyprus, an island that currently holds the European Union's rotating presidency. Cyprus had to clarify that it was not a party to the conflict publicly. The symbolism was stark. A weapon developed by Iran, and previously used by Russia in Ukraine, had now touched EU territory. Security alerts at train stations and airports across the continent underscore a sobering reality: Europe is not insulated from Middle Eastern wars.

What is striking is the relative absence of European criticism of the US-Israeli strikes. Many governments, frustrated by years of Iranian brinkmanship, hostage diplomacy and regional interference, are privately relieved to see pressure applied to Tehran's leadership. Only Spain has openly dissented, with Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez arguing that opposition to an authoritarian regime does not justify military intervention outside international law. That distinction matters. Europe has long presented itself as a champion of multilateralism and legal norms. Silence now risks eroding that identity. At the same time, the continent cannot ignore the economic stakes. Roughly a fifth of globally traded oil passes through the Strait of Hormuz. Iranian threats against shipping in that narrow corridor have already unsettled markets. A prolonged disruption would reverberate through European economies still recovering from inflationary shocks and energy crises triggered by Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

The immediate priority, however, is human. Thousands of Europeans are stranded across the region. Germany estimates that about 30,000 of its citizens — tourists on cruise ships, travellers stuck at closed airports, families whose connecting flights ran through Gulf hubs — are unable to return home. The Czech Republic has begun airlifting nationals via Egypt and Jordan, with additional flights dispatched to Oman. Airspace closures complicate military evacuations, and no coordinated EU-wide operation has yet been launched, though emergency meetings of foreign ministers suggest one may soon be unavoidable. Beyond evacuations lies a broader strategic calculation. France is reinforcing Operation Aspid, the EU naval mission originally established to protect shipping in the Red Sea from Houthi attacks. Yet its mandate remains limited, and any expansion of rules of engagement will take time. Europe's capacity to shape events militarily is constrained; its leverage lies more in diplomacy than firepower.

That diplomatic effort is now being tested. EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas has condemned Iran's retaliatory strikes and warned against further escalation that could threaten Europe itself. Talks with Gulf Cooperation Council states are planned to reassure anxious neighbours and prevent the conflict from spreading. NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte has framed the US-Israeli campaign as relevant to European security, while ruling out direct alliance involvement. This careful calibration reflects institutional memory. NATO's long deployments in Afghanistan and its intervention in Libya left mixed legacies and limited appetite for new entanglements beyond treaty territory. Meanwhile, questions swirl about Iran's political future. European officials insist they have no preferred successor in Tehran and emphasise solidarity with the Iranian people rather than with any faction. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, recently added to the EU's terror list, is unlikely to be treated as a legitimate interlocutor.

Europe thus finds itself in a familiar but uncomfortable position: economically exposed, politically divided and strategically dependent. It wants stability in the Middle East without owning the war; it seeks to deter Iran without endorsing limitless escalation; it aims to uphold international law without alienating its closest ally. The coming weeks will test whether the continent can balance these competing imperatives. If oil prices spike, migration flows intensify, or further strikes hit European-linked assets, pressure for a clearer stance will grow. For now, Europe's posture is defensive and reactive. But wars have a way of redrawing boundaries — geographic, political and moral. The longer this conflict burns, the harder it will be for Europe to remain merely a bystander managing consequences rather than a participant shaping outcomes.

BHARAT
KI SOCH



ANIL RAJPUT

THE WRITER IS
THE CHAIRPERSON,
BHARAT KI SOCH

Leadership
legitimacy is
earned not by
title alone, but by
ethical coherence,
emotional
discipline and
the courage to
subordinate
self-interest

Leadership Beyond the Throne

In an era obsessed with visibility and ambition, Bharat's conduct in the Ramayana offers a timeless lesson in ethical restraint and custodial leadership

*"I do not desire the kingdom; the consecration belongs to Rama alone."
- Valmiki Ramayana, Ayodhya Kanda*

In an age that equates leadership with visibility, titles, and personal branding, the significance of restraint as a quality is often overlooked. To step back, to refuse prominence, or to subordinate one's claim to a larger principle is mistaken for weakness. Yet history shows that for institutions to endure, the qualities of humility, sacrifice, and moral alignment to a larger principle are invaluable. In fact, the strength to decline what one can claim may, at times, reveal deeper authority than the act of actually claiming it.

In the Ramayana, Bharat, the son of King Dasharatha and Queen Kaikeyi, emerges not as a claimant to power but as its conscious custodian, firmly convinced that the kingdom rightfully belonged to Ram. He was not present in Ayodhya when events unfolded, leading to Ram being exiled. Upon his return, he finds the kingdom grieving, his father dead, and the throne legally his to claim. Bharat's immediate recognition of moral breach in denying Ram the throne illustrates that accountability, moral courage, and ethical self-scrutiny precede authority. Institutions regain stability when leaders are willing to question the foundations of their own power.

What follows is one of the most remarkable acts of ethical leadership in epic literature. Rejecting a crown he believed rightfully belonged to his brother, Bharat travels to the forest to persuade Ram to return and assume his rightful position as king. When Ram refuses, bound by his commitment to dharma and their father's vow, Bharat does not contest him further. Instead, he brings back Ram's sandals and places them upon the throne of Ayodhya as a public declaration that the kingdom belonged to Ram alone. This was not symbolic theatre but a deliberate assertion of alignment over rivalry. By placing the sandals on the throne, Bharat affirmed that he governed only as regent until the rightful king returned. Leadership, Bharat demonstrates, must be anchored not merely in entitlement but in moral legitimacy and principled restraint. In corporate life, crises often originate not from external competition but from avoidable internal ethical lapses.

Bharat's journey to the forest also reveals the architecture of principled leadership. He does not send emissaries but goes personally, demonstrating humility before legitimacy. His appeal to Ram is earnest as he does not seek personal gain. Instead, he articulates it as a violation of dharma and seeks redressal. This reflects a leader's responsibility to place institutional continuity and the welfare of the people above personal advantage. Bharat teaches that legitimacy is reinforced through humility, value alignment, and commitment to collective welfare.

His decision to reside in Nandigram



For corporations navigating volatility, Bharat's restraint offers a model of governance rooted in stewardship rather than ambition

rather than in the palace underscores disciplined detachment. Though functioning as administrator of the kingdom, he renounces royal comforts and lives in austerity until Ram's return. Leaders who voluntarily forsake the privileges that accompany authority strengthen ethical coherence. Bharat's austerity affirms that governance is a duty to be fulfilled, not a luxury to be enjoyed, embodying personal integrity, self-discipline, and detachment from privilege.

Bharat's regency also exemplifies operational excellence without assertion of ego. During the fourteen years of Ram's exile, Ayodhya did not descend into uncertainty or factionalism. Administrative systems functioned, justice was dispensed, and public order was preserved. Bharat did not dismantle existing structures nor seek to reshape governance in his personal image. He sustained the institutional framework Ram had upheld, ensuring that the kingdom remained stable and prosperous in his absence. This demonstrates operational competence, institutional continuity, and ego restraint reflected in his refusal to convert temporary authority into personal dominance. His governance was executed without appropriation.

Another dimension of Bharat's leadership lies in emotional discipline. His grief at Ram's exile is genuine and profound, yet he does not allow sorrow to affect governance. Emotion is acknowledged, but duty is not abandoned. Emotional containment strengthens confidence, efficiency, and resilience. In corporate challenges, unchecked display of emotion can destabilise teams and magnify uncertainty. Bharat's composure affirms that personal anguish must not eclipse professional obligation.

Equally significant is Bharat's respect for principled disagreement. Though he believed the kingdom belonged to Ram and urged him to return, Ram remained resolute in honouring their father's vow. This was not a collective decision but a mutual disagreement grounded in shared values. Bharat accepted Ram's choice not

because he was overruled, but because he respected Ram's interpretation of dharma. They agreed to disagree, yet remained united in purpose. In corporate life, leadership maturity is revealed not in the absence of disagreement, but in the ability to sustain institutional alignment despite it. The kingdom, in Bharat's conviction, always belonged to Ram, but he chose value-based action over emotional insistence. Such mutual respect for principle strengthens institutional cohesion and preserves trust within leadership structures.

Bharat's refusal to exploit circumstances reflects long-term vision. He understood that a kingdom gained through moral compromise would lack credibility and durability. Bharat treated his authority as custodial, not permanent. His rule was oriented toward preservation rather than personal consolidation. He believed deeply in Ram's vision for the kingdom and governed in a manner consistent with what he understood Ram's ideals to be. Corporate leaders frequently encounter opportunities that promise short-term gain at ethical cost. Bharat's disciplined decisions caution against such myopia. Markets may reward aggressive acquisition temporarily, but reputational capital erodes when principles are sacrificed.

His conduct further illustrates that influence does not correspond with occupancy of the highest office. During Ram's exile, Bharat, despite not having been announced king, commanded deep respect among citizens and ministers. He did not dismantle the administrative structure; courts functioned, ministers remained in position, and state duties proceeded without disruption. His moral authority exceeded his designation. In contemporary enterprises, leadership influence is increasingly measured by credibility rather than title. Moral stature, not formal position, fosters enduring loyalty and influence.

Another lesson emerges from Bharat's patience while he awaits Ram's return. He measured time not by ambition but by fulfilment of promise. Fourteen years is a

prolonged absence by any standard. Yet he remained steadfast in anticipation of Ram's return. Corporate strategy often falters when leaders prioritise immediate metrics over long-term gains. Bharat's governance demonstrates that endurance, when guided by ethical clarity, becomes an asset.

Bharat also embodies relational leadership. His interactions with the citizens of Ayodhya are marked by empathy and accountability. He shares their sorrow and reassures them through visible action. Leaders who maintain relational proximity cultivate trust, while distance breeds suspicion. Institutions flourish when leaders act with empathy and understanding.

Importantly, Bharat's life challenges the coalescence of ambition with leadership. He possessed the credentials for success, such as capability, lineage, and opportunity, yet did not seek personal advancement at the cost of ethical coherence. While aspiration drives innovation, untempered ambition destabilises governance. Bharat teaches that aspiration must align with institutional welfare. Leadership is validated not by ascent alone, but by integrity in ascent.

As the period of exile concludes, Bharat awaits Ram's return with unwavering commitment. When Ram reclaims the throne, Bharat steps aside without hesitation or remorse. There is no attempt to renegotiate authority or retain residual power. He organises the welcome and prepares the kingdom for Ram's coronation, treating the transfer not as a loss of power but as a fulfilment of obligation. This seamless transfer reinforces institutional continuity. Transition planning remains one of the most sensitive dimensions of corporate governance. Bharat's voluntary relinquishment affirms that the true measure of stewardship lies in enabling smooth transition.

The Ramayana is recognised not merely for its epic grandeur but for its exploration of ethical dilemmas of leadership. Bharat's narrative demonstrates that moral restraint can wield greater influence than conquest and that stewardship surpasses possession. In an era when corporations are called upon to serve a broader purpose beyond mere productivity, Bharat's example assumes contemporary resonance. Alignment with foundational values, humility in stewardship, emotional discipline in crisis, patience in strategy, and integrity in transition are not abstract virtues. They are practical foundations for enduring enterprise.

As corporations navigate technological transformation, regulatory scrutiny, and evolving social expectations, the need for leaders who embody custodial responsibility has never been greater. Bharat stands as a civilisational archetype of such leadership. His conduct affirms that the most resilient institutions are not those that accumulate power, but those that ground power in ethical stewardship. By placing righteousness above rank and duty above desire, he illustrates that the true sovereign in any organisation is not the individual who occupies the throne, but the principle that legitimises it.

Views expressed are personal

GLOBAL
FAULTLINES



MOUSUMI ROY

THE WRITER WRITES
ABOUT POLITICS,
MATERIAL CULTURE,
AND ECONOMIC
HISTORY

For India,
instability
between
Washington
and Tehran
carries real
economic
and strategic
consequences

Cost of Walking Away

America's withdrawal from the Iran nuclear agreement weakened verified restraints, fractured alliances, and raised difficult questions about global diplomatic credibility and continuity

When the United States withdrew from the Iran nuclear deal in May 2018, it did not merely abandon a controversial agreement. It weakened one of the most significant diplomatic frameworks of the 21st century and signalled that even verified compliance might not guarantee continuity in American commitments. The 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) was never presented as a grand reconciliation between Washington and Tehran. It was narrow by design. Its purpose was singular: to prevent Iran from developing a nuclear weapon. Under the agreement, Iran capped uranium enrichment at 3.67 per cent, reduced its enriched uranium stockpile by roughly 97 per cent, dismantled thousands of centrifuges, and allowed continuous monitoring by the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). The inspections were intrusive. Facilities were monitored in real time. For several years, the IAEA repeatedly verified that Iran was complying with its obligations.

Whatever one thought of the deal's limitations, its sunset clauses, its failure to address Iran's ballistic missile program, or its regional activities, the core objective was being met, Iran's nuclear breakout time had been significantly extended, and the program was under international surveillance. Then, President Donald Trump withdrew the United States from the agreement, calling it "the worst deal ever negotiated." In its place came the "maximum pressure" campaign sweeping sanctions targeting Iranian oil exports, banking networks, and foreign trade. The administration argued that harsher economic isolation would force Tehran back to the negotiating table for a broader, tougher agreement. That assumption proved deeply flawed. Sanctions without a credible diplomatic off-ramp are not negotiation. They are



The Iran nuclear deal was imperfect — but it worked. Its collapse reshaped diplomacy, weakened trust and raised urgent questions about global stability

coercion without resolution. And coercion without resolution often leads not to capitulation but to recalibration.

Beginning in 2019, Iran gradually reduced its compliance with the JCPOA. Enrichment levels rose beyond the agreed 3.67 per cent cap. Stockpiles increased. Advanced centrifuges were reintroduced. By 2021, enrichment had reached 60 per cent, far beyond the limits of the 2015 agreement, though still short of weapons-grade material. The sequence matters. Iran's escalation followed the U.S. withdrawal; it did not precede it.

This is not Tehran's intention or policy. Iran's regional posture remains deeply contentious. But the nuclear deal had created a functioning, verifiable restraint mechanism. When Washington exited despite confirmed Iranian compliance, it eroded the incentives underpinning that restraint. The consequences extended beyond the nuclear file.

Inside Iran, factions sceptical of engagement with the West were strengthened. The argument that the United

States cannot be trusted gained credibility. European allies struggled to preserve the deal without U.S. participation, attempting limited workarounds that ultimately failed to offset American sanctions. The diplomatic coalition that had made the JCPOA possible fractured. More importantly, the withdrawal sent a signal globally: multilateral agreements negotiated across administrations may not survive domestic political change. Foreign policy credibility is not built solely on military strength. It rests on consistency. When a state abides by an agreement, and sanctions are reimposed years later, the logic of reciprocity, the foundation of arms control, weakens.

Consider the broader implications. If compliance does not secure durable relief, why would future adversaries accept intrusive inspections? Why would they invest political capital in negotiating constraints if those constraints can be reversed with an election cycle?

Supporters of the withdrawal argued that the JCPOA was insufficient because

it addressed only nuclear issues while leaving other disputes unresolved. That critique may hold weight. But dismantling a functioning nuclear restraint mechanism without securing an immediate replacement did not create leverage. It created a vacuum. Diplomacy with adversaries is rarely comprehensive. It proceeds incrementally, through bounded agreements that manage specific risks. The Iran deal was precisely that: bounded, focused, verifiable. Its collapse has left the region more volatile. Nuclear tensions have increased rather than decreased. Trust between Washington and Tehran has deteriorated further. And the global non-proliferation regime has been weakened at a time when restraint is more necessary than ever.

For countries like India, which maintain economic and strategic ties across West Asia, the stakes are not abstract. Energy security, diaspora safety, and regional stability all depend on reducing escalatory cycles between the United States and Iran. Diplomatic breakdowns in the Gulf ripple outward into global markets and geopolitical alignments. The lesson of the past decade is clear. Diplomacy is fragile. It requires continuity beyond politics. Agreements that survive only as long as the administration that signed them remains in office cannot anchor international stability.

The JCPOA was imperfect. Most diplomatic agreements are. But it was functioning. Its abandonment did not produce a better deal. It produced greater uncertainty. The central question today is not whether the original deal solved every problem between Washington and Tehran. It did not. The real question is whether discarding verified nuclear constraints in pursuit of maximalist objectives has made the world safer. The evidence suggests that it has not.

Views expressed are personal

Britain sending warship to Cyprus after drone strike on UK base: PM

LONDON: Prime Minister Keir Starmer said Tuesday that Britain is sending a warship and helicopters to Cyprus after a drone hit a UK base there. Starmer said he had told the island's president that the UK is deploying helicopters with counter-drone capabilities and the air-defense destroyer HMS Dragon to the region. It comes after an Iran-made drone hit RAF Akrotiri base over the weekend, causing minor damage and no injuries. Spokesperson Constantinos Letymbiotis had said the incident at RAF Akrotiri occurred shortly after midnight Monday. He said "information received through various channels" indicated a drone strike. He didn't specify what kind of drone, where it was launched from or the extent of damage. Letymbiotis said Cypriot authorities have enacted security protocols and are monitoring the situation in coordination with the UK and its two military bases in Cyprus. The suspected drone strike occurred after British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said the UK would help the US in the war against Iran.

AGENCIES

IRAN HAS TARGETED MULTIPLE US BASES IN GULF STATES

‘Putin in close contact with Gulf leaders to facilitate de-escalation’

MOSCOW: Russian President Vladimir Putin is making all possible efforts to de-escalate the crisis in the Gulf and is in close contact with the regional leaders as Iran is retaliating with massive strikes on the US facilities and infrastructure on their territories, the Kremlin said on Tuesday.

The US and Israel launched joint strikes against Iran on Saturday, assassinating 86-year-old Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, alongside family members, including his daughter and grandchildren. Since then, Iran has targeted multiple US bases in the surrounding Gulf States. "Putin will certainly make every effort to facilitate at least a minor easing of tensions. In this regard, we discussed with virtually all of our interlocutors yesterday," the Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said. "Taking advantage of the dialogue we maintain with the Iranian leadership, (President) Putin will convey his deep concern regarding the strikes on their infrastructure



Late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei (right), and Russian President Vladimir Putin greet each other during their meeting in Tehran

AP/FILE PHOTO

to our colleagues in Iran," he added. According to the Kremlin, Putin spoke by telephone with leaders of Bahrain, Qatar, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia. In his telephonic conversation with Crown Prince

and Chairman of the Council of Ministers of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, Mohammed bin Salman, Putin discussed

Vladimir Putin underscored the urgent need to resolve the current extremely dangerous situation through political and diplomatic means, the Kremlin said

The escalating situation in the region as a result of the American-Israeli armed aggression against Iran. "Both sides expressed serious concern over the real risks of escalation of the conflict, which has already affected several Arab countries and is fraught with catastrophic consequences. In this context, Vladimir Putin underscored the urgent need to resolve the current extremely dangerous situation through political and diplomatic means," the Kremlin said.

AGENCIES

Russia bans prominent LGBTQ+ rights group as extremist

MOSCOW: A court in Russia on Tuesday designated a prominent LGBTQ+ rights group as an extremist organisation, the latest blow to the country's beleaguered community that has faced an intensified crackdown in recent years under President Vladimir Putin. In a hearing that took place behind closed doors, the St Petersburg City Court banned the Coming Out group as "extremist". The authorities did not reveal any details of the lawsuit filed last month by Russia's Justice Ministry and classified as secret.

The group, which now operates from abroad, said it will continue to help LGBTQ+ people in Russia and beyond, and fight for their rights despite the ruling. "We have been preparing for this development for a long time. We enhanced security, developed sustainable work formats and continue to act responsibly, first and foremost for those who count on us," Coming Out said in an online statement. "Today it is especially important not to give into fear and not to be alone. Our community is stronger than any

Similar lawsuits have been filed against two other LGBTQ+ rights groups, with courts in St Petersburg and the Samara region still to rule on them

labels, and history has proven that." Coming Out is the first LGBTQ+ rights group to be designated since the 2023 Supreme Court ruling that effectively banned any LGBTQ+ activism. Similar lawsuits have been filed against two other LGBTQ+ rights groups, with courts in St Petersburg and the Samara region still to rule on them. Russia's LGBTQ+ community has been under legal and public pressure for over a decade, but especially since the Kremlin invaded Ukraine four years ago. Putin has argued that the war in Ukraine is a proxy battle with the West, which he says aims to destroy Russia and its "traditional family values" by pushing for LGBTQ+ rights.

AGENCIES

Students, activists stage protest outside US Consulate in Lahore

LAHORE/KARACHI: Pakistani students and rights activists on Tuesday staged a demonstration outside the US Consulate in Lahore to protest the assassination of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and the killing of a dozen protesters by the US Marines in Karachi.

A heavy contingent of police, including women personnel, was deployed outside the American Consulate to handle the demonstrators. Police have also placed containers on all routes leading to the consulate. Protesters representing the Progressive Students and the 'Aurat March' chanted slogans against the US and Israel for attacking Iran and killing its supreme leader. "America ka jo yar hai, gaddar hai gaddar hai (Friend of America is a traitor)." They also condemned the firing of US Marines on protesters outside the American Consulate in Karachi that resulted in the death of a dozen people. The protesters demanded the immediate expulsion of the US ambassador from Pakistan. They said the killing of the supreme leader is a loss for the entire Muslim Ummah. They said his only fault was refusing



Shiite Muslims set a fire at the US Consulate's entrance gate during a rally to condemn the killing of Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, in Lahore

AP/PTI

regime change in Iran. The protesters also called for an immediate ceasefire between Pakistan and Afghanistan. Over 20 people were killed during protests in Pakistan following the assassination of Ayatollah Khamenei. Pakistan's Majlis Wahdat-i-Muslimeen (MWM) chief and opposition leader in the Senate, Allama Raja Nasir Abbas, claimed that at least 34 people were killed in the country during the clashes with law enforcers while protesting the assassination of the Iranian supreme leader. "On Sunday in Karachi, 18 people were killed and more than 40 injured. In Islamabad, four people lost their lives and dozens were injured. In Skardu and Gilgit, six people were killed in each city, with dozens more injured. And in Lahore, dozens were also injured during the crackdown," Abbas said. Lambasting the US Marines for the killing of 18 people in Karachi, the Senate opposition leader said: "The firing by personnel of the United States Marine Corps on unarmed demonstrators at Karachi US Consulate is condemnable in the strongest terms."

AGENCIES

World Briefs

RINIDAD AND TOBAGO DECLARES NEW STATE OF EMERGENCY

PORT-OF-SPAIN: Trinidad and Tobago declared a new state of emergency Tuesday, only about a month after the end of the previous one, as authorities in the Caribbean nation continue to grapple with high levels of violent crime. Prime Minister Kamla Persad-Bissessar cited credible reports of attacks planned against law enforcement officers in reimposing the emergency, which grants the government additional powers, including to make arrests and conduct searches without warrants.

SINGAPORE EXPANDS FOREIGN WORKFORCE,

SINGAPORE: Singapore on Tuesday announced an expansion of its foreign manpower policy, opening eight service-sector jobs to workers from more countries, including India, from September and introducing a new work pass from 2027 to attract global talent in emerging technologies. Manpower Minister Tan See Leng said eight occupations in social, food, and air transport services will be added to the Non-Traditional Occupation (NTS) Occupation List from September.

Ahead of polls, two injured in blast in Nepal's Madhes

KATHMANDU: Two people were injured when a suspicious object exploded in Nepal's Madhes province on Tuesday, just two days ahead of the March 5 general election, police said. The incident occurred on the East-West Highway in Bardibas in Mahottari district when the unidentified object exploded near a bridge, injuring two pedestrians, police said. The injured were identified as Sandesh Chaudhary, 17, and Samir Chaudhary, 24. They were admitted to a local hospital and their condition was stated to be stable.

AGENCIES

भारत सरकार

कारपोरेट कार्य मंत्रालय

त्वरित कॉर्पोरेट समापन प्रसंस्करण केंद्र (सी-पेस),

आई.आई.सी.ए. बिल्डिंग, 7वीं मंज़िल,

प्लॉट P-6,7,8, से.-5, आई.एम.टी. मानेसर, गुडगाँव,

हरियाणा - 122050.

Email: roc.cpace@mca.gov.in

सत्यमेव जयते

Government of India

Ministry of Corporate Affairs

Centre for Processing Accelerated

Corporate Exit (C-PACE)

IICA Building, 7th Floor,

Plot P-6,7,8, Sector-5, IMT Manesar,

Gurgaon, Haryana - 122050.

Email: roc.cpace@mca.gov.in

FORM No. STK –6

PUBLIC NOTICE

[Pursuant to sub-section (2) and sub-section (4) of section 248 of the Companies Act, 2013 and rule 7 of the Companies (Removal of Names of Companies from the Register of Companies) Rules, 2016]

Public Notice:ROC/C-PACE/STK-2/248(2)/2025-26/2042

Date: 24/02/2026

Reference:

In the matter of striking off or removal of names of (62) companies in the state **Delhi** under section 248 of the Companies Act, 2013 in respect of:

S No	Work Item	CIN	Company Name
1	AC1494344	U80301DL2012PTC232760	TECHATHENE SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
2	AC1150741	U24299DL2022PTC398158	SHYLA CARE PRIVATE LIMITED
3	AC1378319	U22219DL2013PTC257309	KHANDELA DEVELOPERS PRIVATE LIMITED
4	AC1506636	U72900DL2021PTC385352	SKAZA SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
5	AC1471694	U72900DL2020PTC370203	MORTECH INFOSOL PRIVATE LIMITED
6	AC1042074	U72200DL2017PTC319172	UBABEL SOFTWARE PRIVATE LIMITED
7	AC1543176	U72900DL2014PTC263666	EVD EMARKET PRIVATE LIMITED
8	AC1530259	U45204DL2011PTC220720	GOLDEN DAWN ENGINEERING AND CONSTRUCTION PRIVATE LIMITED
9	AC2253399	U41001DL2023PTC413393	TECHVEIN CONSTRUCTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
10	AC2317965	U32109DL1999PTC100886	PREPACK ENGINEERING AND SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
11	AC2313655	U69100DL2023PTC424187	BANIRUHA SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
12	AC0565562	U74140DL2008PTC176408	RMD E COM MANAGEMENT & PROFESSIONAL SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
13	AC2334215	U51909DL2018PTC334774	EPINICIAN SALES PRIVATE LIMITED
14	AC2329519	U74899DL1989PTC035824	H. KHURANA AND COMPANY PRIVATE LIMITED
15	AC1714852	U74999DL2017PTC316911	CONFINET IT SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
16	AC1877641	U74999DL2022OPC405533	HAREWALK CULTURE (OPC) PRIVATE LIMITED
17	AC2162785	U74999DL2020PTC367879	AAMN LIVING PRIVATE LIMITED
18	AC2002515	U67100DL2023PTC410154	OSCAR FOREX PRIVATE LIMITED
19	AC1739337	U80902DL2021PTC377477	VY AVIATION TRAINING PRIVATE LIMITED
20	AC1269001	U92412DL2007PTC165316	ALOR GOLF COURSE PRIVATE LIMITED
21	AC2341707	U64204DL2017PTC323171	ALI SHAN TECHNO SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
22	AC1271175	U45200DL2008PTC179142	UNI HOMES PRIVATE LIMITED
23	AC1238120	U72200DL2022PTC407217	PERCEPTA AUTOPILO TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED
24	AC1837003	U72900DL2019PTC344430	CAMPUS EDGE PRIVATE LIMITED
25	AC2010130	U59112DL2025PTC455427	DIGITAL NEXARC GROWTH PRIVATE LIMITED
26	AC2040120	U74999DL2021PTC381884	SUNNYTECH MARINE SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
27	AC2088399	U58203DL2025PTC446734	SPINEOWL PRIVATE LIMITED
28	AC2126411	U52603DL2019PTC349530	JOYIER ELECTRONICS PRIVATE LIMITED
29	AC2113824	U51909DL2011PTC222574	OPULENT ENTERPRISES PRIVATE LIMITED
30	AC2118858	U70109DL2013PTC258441	YAVI CONSTECH PRIVATE LIMITED
31	AC2154207	U33100DL2022PTC400510	BRAINOVATIVE LABS PRIVATE LIMITED
32	AC2130191	U67110DL2013PTC247566	TEAM GENUS FINANCIAL SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
33	AC2300001	U62099DL2023PTC415173	JBS IT - AUTOMATION PRIVATE LIMITED
34	AC2156257	U73100DL2021PTC383385	IRDDAC SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
35	AC2157598	U62091DL2023PTC422823	THINKSCRATCH SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
36	AC2167941	U70200DL2023OPC410623	EAZIFY FINANCIAL CONSULTANTS (OPC) PRIVATE LIMITED
37	AC2195502	U74999DL2016PTC298289	PARAKRAM HEALTH & FITNESS PRIVATE LIMITED
38	AC2290152	U74999DL2019PTC349420	AVJAP ENVIRO PRIVATE LIMITED
39	AC2182926	U51909DL2020PTC370731	BREW GREEN PRIVATE LIMITED
40	AC2204062	U74899DL1989PTC036945	VANDHANA ESTATES AND LEASING PRIVATE LIMITED
41	AC2200793	U80900DL2015PTC278597	HUMANANAT ACADEMIA PRIVATE LIMITED
42	AC2183603	U15400DL2016PTC290325	QUALEMAGNI PRIVATE LIMITED
43	AC2172915	U93000DL2011PTC226756	ARDEEG PROJECT VENTURES PRIVATE LIMITED
44	AC2229150	U47211DL2023PTC417160	FARMSHINE AGRITECH PRIVATE LIMITED
45	AC2177054	U29309DL2018PTC333370	POLRED EQUIPMENTS PRIVATE LIMITED
46	AC2211270	U63000DL2012PTC230742	BRACK CAPITAL LOGISTICS & INFRASTRUCTURE INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED
47	AC2204756	U46909DL2023PTC423757	MEDTREUX PHARMA PRIVATE LIMITED
48	AC2228688	U70103DL2019PTC347934	ACHLA BUILDCON PRIVATE LIMITED
49	AC2203523	U86100DL2023PTC410729	NAYAK MULTI SPECIALITY HOSPITAL PRIVATE LIMITED
50	AC2194897	U01114DL2019PTC350477	FIRELANCE TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED
51	AC2286090	U74994DL1997PTC090441	DD INTERIOR AND DECOR PRIVATE LIMITED
52	AC2292507	U74140DL2010PTC198475	MIRACLE EVENT & SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
53	AC2231546	U52100DL2014PTC271844	MITHLESH TRADING PRIVATE LIMITED
54	AC2285710	U74999DL2021PTC376596	JK MANGAL AUTO PARTS PRIVATE LIMITED
55	AC2252292	U74999DL2018PTC333593	LEMEANARTE PRIVATE LIMITED
56	AC2246453	U70109DL2022PTC394760	STAYHO PRIVATE LIMITED
57	AC2267390	U85320DL2018PTC337659	COSMOTREE CLINIC PRIVATE LIMITED
58	AC2254322	U01111DL2020PTC370777	PURAL ORGANICS PRIVATE LIMITED
59	AC2276089	U80900DL2018PTC330640	HOUSE OF LEARNING PRIVATE LIMITED
60	AC2273210	U64203DL2014PTC266971	MOBI SERVE PRIVATE LIMITED
61	AC2266083	U74899DL1995PTC068493	NAVEEN AGENCIES PRIVATE LIMITED
62	AC2286285	U73100DL2025OPC459605	BRANDING VALA MARKETING (OPC) PRIVATE LIMITED

2. Notice is hereby given that the Registrar of Companies had received applications from the above-mentioned companies under section 248(2) of the Companies Act, 2013 for removal of its/their name (s) from the register of companies either on the ground that they have failed to commence business within one year of their incorporation or on the ground that the company(ies) is/are not carrying on any business or operation for a period of two immediately preceding financial years and has/have not made any application (s) within such period for obtaining the status of a dormant company under section 455 of the Companies Act, 2013 or the company(ies) have obtained the status of dormant company/subscribers to the memorandum have not paid the subscription which they had undertaken to pay at the time of incorporation of a company and a declaration to this effect has not been filed within one hundred and eighty days of its incorporation under subsection (1) of section 10A/ have not been carrying on any business or operations, as revealed after the physical verification carried out under sub-section (9) of section 12, but it/they do not wish to continue its/their registration as companies and have, therefore, requested for removal/strike off of its/their names from the register of companies.

3. Accordingly, the Registrar of Companies proposes to remove or strike off the names of the above-mentioned companies from the Register of Companies.

4. Any person objecting to the proposed removal or striking off name of the companies from the register of companies may send his or her objection to the office address mentioned here above within thirty days from the date of publication of this notice.

Irkan Turkey
Deputy Registrar
Centre for Processing Accelerated Corporate Exit

CBC 07123/11/0734/2526

WEST ASIA CRISIS INTENSIFIES

Netanyahu takes a gamble on US support for Israel with Iran war

JERUSALEM: Throughout his political career, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has steered his country along two pillars of foreign policy: an ironclad partnership with the United States and a relentless diplomatic and covert battle against the rulers of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Now, with Israel and the US in a joint war against Iran's leadership, those two strategic paths risk clashing with each other. By enlisting the US in what he views as Israel's existential battle against Iran, Netanyahu is taking a gamble that could open up the relationship to the strain of a war with far-reaching consequences.

To be sure, persuading US President Donald Trump to join the war was a coup for Netanyahu and highlights the strong ties between the two leaders. If they are successful, they could quickly realize their



Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu during a visit to the site of a missile strike, in Bet Shemesh on Monday

shared goal of toppling the Iranian government and spare the region a protracted conflict.

But if the war drags on, the two allies' ties could again be tested.

"A large part of the American public will view it as the Israeli tail wagging the American dog and that it is dragging

the United States to a war in the Middle East that isn't theirs," said Ofer Shelah, a research fellow at the Institute for National Security Studies, a Tel Aviv, Israel-based think tank. The drop in public support that might unleash "will be very harmful for Israel in the medium and long term,"

Highlights

- » With Israel and US in a joint war against Iran's leadership, those two strategic paths risk clashing with each other
- » But if the war drags on, the two allies' ties could again be tested

THE DROP IN PUBLIC SUPPORT THAT MIGHT UNLEASH 'WILL BE VERY HARMFUL FOR ISRAEL'

he said. But, he added, in a nod to the Israeli leader's political ambitions: "Netanyahu is not interested in the medium and long term."

For Netanyahu, successfully persuading Trump to strike Iran together is the apex of decades of proximity between the Israeli leader

and Washington. Netanyahu, Israel's longest-serving leader, speaks flawless English after having spent part of his youth in the US and has always portrayed himself as Israel's bridge to America.

Although he boasts about his tight relationships with multiple American presidents and members of Congress, Netanyahu over the past two years has seen support for Israel among the American public drop. According to Gallup polling, American sympathies in the Middle East have shifted dramatically toward the Palestinians. That shift in sentiment has been driven in large part by Democrats. But some Republicans, and even Trump's own backers, have been more outspoken against the diplomatic and financial support the US has continued to grant Israel throughout the past two and a half years.

IAEA: Natanz nuclear site suffered some damage

'No radiological consequence expected'

VIENNA: The United Nations' nuclear watchdog said Tuesday Iran's Natanz nuclear enrichment site sustained "some recent damage" amid a US-Israeli airstrike campaign, though there was "no radiological consequence expected" from it.

The International Atomic Energy Agency said the damage was focused on "entrance buildings" to the underground portion of the atomic site.

The Natanz site, some 220 kilometres (135 miles) south of the capital, is a mix of above- and below-ground laboratories that did the majority of Iran's uranium enrichment.

Before the war, the IAEA said Iran used advanced centrifuges there to enrich uranium up to 60 per cent — a short, technical step from weapons-grade levels of 90 per cent.

Some of the material is presumed to have been onsite when the entire complex was attacked last June.

The main above-ground enrichment building at Natanz was known as the Pilot Fuel

The IAEA said the damage was focused on 'entrance buildings' to the underground portion of the atomic site

Enrichment Plant. Israel hit the building on June 13, leaving it "functionally destroyed," and seriously damaging underground halls holding cascades of centrifuges, the IAEA's director-general, Rafael Grossi, said at the time. A US follow-up attack on June 22 hit Natanz's underground facilities with bunker-busting bombs, likely decimating what remained.

Addressing the special session of the Board of Governors, IAEA chief Rafael Mariano Grossi said that "up to now" the International Atomic Energy Agency has "no indication that any of the nuclear installations.

US sanctions Rwanda's military, top officials

KINSHASA: The US imposed sanctions Monday on the Rwandan Defence Forces and four of its senior officials for supporting the March 23 Movement, an armed group responsible for human rights abuses in the central African nation of Congo.

The latest penalties come after a US-mediated peace agreement was signed in December by Congolese President Felix Tshisekedi and Rwandan President Paul Kagame in Washington, alongside Trump. Trump at the time praised the leaders for their courage, as the deal also opened the region's critical mineral reserves to the US government and US companies. Despite the agreement, fighting between the two parties continues on several fronts in eastern Congo, claiming numerous civilian and military casualties.

Pak forces kill 67 Taliban personnel in overnight operations: Minister

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan security forces killed another 67 Afghan Taliban personnel in overnight operations, repulsing their attacks at 16 locations along the southwestern border early Tuesday, officials said.

Information Minister Attaullah Tarar provided updates on the ongoing Operation Ghazab lil Haq, launched on Feb 26 in response to the Afghan Taliban raids.

Tarar said that 40 Afghan Taliban personnel were killed in overnight operations in the border region along the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province.

"Physical attack was attempted at one place, while



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

a fire raid was conducted on 12 locations, which were all repulsed without any loss of life," he said in an update posted on X.

"At least 40 Afghan Taliban were killed in the overnight operations in KP," he said, adding

that "follow-up" operations continued.

Separately, the Afghan Taliban resorted to physical attack from across the border on 16 locations in Northern Balochistan in Qilla Saifullah, Noshki and Chaman districts while engaging Pakistan troops on 25 locations in a fire raid.

"The attacks at all the locations were repulsed with Afghan Taliban suffering 27 killed and scores injured," he said. The minister also said that one soldier of the paramilitary Frontier Corps (FC) Balochistan North was killed while five soldiers were injured.

KATHMANDU: Nepal is holding parliamentary elections Thursday, a year after a youth-led uprising forced out the government chosen in the last elections.

3 years
The election is being held just three years after Nepal's previous national vote, following the political upheaval that led to the government's collapse in 2025. That paved the way for an interim government, which later called for fresh elections.

18.9 million registered voters

Nearly 19 million people are registered to vote in Nepal, according to the Election Commission.



A security personnel stands guard at an Army barracks ahead of the parliamentary elections, in Kathmandu on Tuesday

mission. About 966,000 are men and 924,000 are women. Another 200 voters are registered under the "others" category,

which includes people who do not identify as male or female and members of the LGBTQ+ community.

1 million more voters than previous polls

The number of registered voters has risen by nearly 1 million since the last parliamentary election in November 2022, as the youth-led uprising sparked greater interest in politics. The voting age in Nepal is 18, and authorities had urged eligible young adults to register.

The youth-led uprising in September 2025 that brought down the previous government and triggered early elections has become a defining issue in the campaign.

Political parties have pledged to amplify the voices of younger voters, promising to

tackle corruption and improve governance.

275 parliamentarians are being chosen

Voters will directly elect 165 members to the House of Representatives, the powerful lower chamber of Parliament. The remaining 110 seats in the 275-member House will be filled through a proportional representation system, with political parties nominating lawmakers based on the share of votes each party receives.

Previous government in Nepal have largely been coalitions, with two or more parties joining forces to command a majority in the House.

सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

दिल्ली में भरने हैं
विकास
के रंग

आप सभी को होली की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएं

यह पर्व आपके जीवन में सुख, समृद्धि और आनंद के नए रंग भरे

A CALL FOR 'DIALOGUE AND DIPLOMACY'

As Mideast conflict intensifies, India flags risks to trade & energy security

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: As the conflict in West Asia widened, India on Tuesday emphasised the interest of one crore Indian nationals in the region and voiced concern over consequences for the Indian economy due to possible disruptions in energy supplies, even as Prime Minister Narendra Modi discussed the precarious situation with leaders of Oman, Kuwait and Qatar.

In its second statement since the US-Israel strikes on Iran and Tehran's subsequent retaliation, India once again called for "dialogue and diplomacy" to end the conflict, noting that New Delhi has critical stakes in the security and stability of West Asia and the current developments "evoke great anxiety".

New Delhi said it will continue to closely monitor the evolving situation and take relevant



An Iranian flag is placed among the ruins of a police station struck Monday during the US-Israel military campaign in Tehran

HIGHLIGHTS

- » New Delhi said it will continue to closely monitor the evolving situation and take relevant decisions in the national interest
- » India is in touch with the governments in the region as well as other key partners, it added
- » The MEA said almost one crore Indian citizens are living in West Asia and their safety and well-being are of 'utmost priority' for New Delhi

evant decisions in the national interest, adding that it is in touch with the governments in the region as well as other key partners. "In recent days, we have not only witnessed an intensification of the conflict but also its spread to other nations. The destruction and deaths have mounted, even as

normal life and economic activities come to a halt," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said.

"As a proximate neighbour with critical stakes in the security and stability of the region, these developments evoke great anxiety,"

The ministry said almost

one crore Indian citizens are living in West Asia and their safety and well-being are of "utmost priority" for New Delhi. "We cannot be impervious to any development that negatively affects them," it said.

"Our trade and energy supply chains also traverse this geography. Any major disruption

has serious consequences for the Indian economy," the ministry said.

The Strait of Hormuz handles nearly 20 per cent of the world's total oil and gas supplies. About 50 per cent of India's oil imports or roughly 2.6 million barrels a day pass through the Strait.

"As a country whose nationals are prominent in the global workforce, India is also firmly opposed to attacks on merchant shipping. Already, some Indian nationals have lost their lives or are missing as a result of such attacks in the last few days," it said. "In this background, India strongly reiterates its call for dialogue and diplomacy. We raise our voice clearly in favour of an early end to the conflict. Already, many lives have been regrettably lost and we express our grief in that regard," it added.

AAI COMMUNICATION AMID MIDEAST CRISIS

Info on fuel stocks sought from int'l airport operators

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/MUMBAI:

State-owned Airports Authority of India (AAI) has asked all international airport operators in the country to provide details about available fuel stocks as well as estimated requirements for the next seven days amid the escalating Middle East crisis, sources said on Tuesday.

The communication comes against the backdrop of the escalating conflict in the Middle East involving the US, Israel and Iran that threatens to impact global oil supplies.

One of the sources said the details have been sought as a "precautionary measure" to have a clear understanding about the fuel supply situation at the international airports.

The sources said that following directions from the civil aviation ministry, AAI has sought details about the current fuel supply status from all the

KEY POINTS

- » One of the sources said the details have been sought as a 'precautionary measure' to have a clear understanding about the fuel supply situation at the international airports
- » The sources said that the

information was sought following directions from the Civil Aviation ministry

- » They have also been asked to provide details about average daily fuel consumption, estimated fuel requirement for the next 7 days and date of next scheduled fuel replenishment

international airport operators.

The operators have also been asked to provide details about average daily fuel consumption, estimated fuel requirement for the next seven days and date of next scheduled fuel replenishment, the sources said. India has 33 international airports, including at Delhi, Mumbai, Bangalore, Hyderabad and Chennai.

In terms of international flight operations, there were 355 departures and 344 arrivals at the airports in the coun-

try on March 2, as per the data available with the ministry.

According to reports, many ships have come under attack in the Strait of Hormuz, a key conduit for global energy flows. Around one-third of the world's seaborne crude oil exports and about 20 per cent of liquefied natural gas shipments transit through the Strait of Hormuz.

It is located between Oman and Iran and connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea.

Delhi: NBCC to build KV campus at Khajuri Khas

NEW DELHI:

The 'Bhoomi Poojan' ceremony for the permanent campus of Kendriya Vidyalaya at Khajuri Khas in Delhi was held on Monday, in the presence of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Education minister Ashish Sood, BJP MP Manoj Tiwari, Law minister Kapil Mishra, and NBCC Chief General Manager Rajeev Kumar.

The ceremony was also attended by senior officials of Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan and NBCC.

The Chief Minister had announced in October 2025 that a new Kendriya Vidyalaya would be opened in Khajuri Khas to expand access to quality education in north-east Delhi. NBCC has been entrusted with the construction of the two-section school building and development of facilities at an estimated cost of Rs 47.80 crore. The project is scheduled for completion within 24 months.

The new academic building will be constructed on a 1.82-acre plot with a built-up area of 8,725 square metres. The ground plus four-storey structure, with a height of 17.5 metres, will accommodate 1,520 students.

It will include 38 classrooms, a double-height entrance lobby with a statue of Goddess Saraswati, a multipurpose court, a Bal Vatika play area, lift access and parking facilities. Provision has also been made for 10 additional classrooms in future.

The campus will incorporate solar power systems, LED lighting, rainwater harvesting, a sewage treatment plant, EV charging points and nearly 25% green cover to meet 4-Star GRIHA sustainability standards.

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The cumulative gross revenue of telecom service providers crossed the Rs 1 lakh crore mark in the December 2025 quarter to Rs 1.02 lakh crore, according to a report by sector regulator Trai, published on Tuesday.

The gross revenue of telecom service providers (TSPs) was Rs 96,390 crore a year ago and Rs 99,828 crore in the September 2025 quarter.

The adjusted gross revenue (AGR) grew by 8.13 per cent on a year-over-year basis to Rs 84,270 crore in the December 2025 quarter, from Rs 77,934 crore in the same period a year ago.

The adjusted gross revenue (AGR) is derived from the sale of telecom services and government levies, including licence fees and spectrum usage charges.

Access service providers, which are players like Reliance

TAKEAWAYS

- » The gross revenue of telecom service providers was Rs 96,390 crore a year ago and Rs 99,828 crore in the September 2025 quarter
- » The AGR grew by 8.13 per cent on a year-over-year basis to Rs 84,270

cr in the December 2025 quarter, from Rs 77,934 crore in the same period a year ago

- » Access service providers, which are players like Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel, Vodafone Idea, etc., accounted for 84.54 per cent of total AGR in the December 2025 quarter

Jio, Bharti Airtel, Vodafone Idea, etc., accounted for 84.54 per cent of total AGR in the December 2025 quarter.

The AGR data published till the September 2025 quarter by the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) in the performance indicator report shows that Reliance Jio topped the chart with revenue of Rs 31,767.11 crore.

It was followed by Bharti Airtel with an AGR of Rs 28,497.45 crore, Vodafone

Idea with Rs 8,176.62 crore. State-run BSNL, which has turned profitable, has reported a decline of 12.61 per cent year-over-year in AGR to Rs 2,003.48 crore. BSNL's sister concern MTNL posted about a 75 per cent decline in AGR on a year-on-year basis to Rs 37.77 crore. The government's licence fees collection grew by 8 per cent on a year-on-year basis to Rs 6,733 crore, and spectrum usage charges were up by 3.19 per cent to Rs 1,020 crore.

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: At least three Indian seafarers on board foreign-flagged vessels were killed and one was injured in the Middle East region, the Directorate General of Shipping said on Tuesday as it issued an advisory for maritime operators to assess voyage-specific risks, amid escalated military actions involving the US, Israel and Iran that threaten disruptions of major trade routes.

"There have been four reported incidents involving Indian seafarers in the region, resulting in three casualties and one injured seafarer, all of whom were serving on board foreign-flagged vessels," the Directorate General of Shipping said.

In an advisory, the Directorate General of Shipping said it is closely monitoring the evolving maritime security situation in the Persian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz, Gulf of Oman and adjoining

INSIGHT

- » In an advisory, the Directorate General of Shipping said it is closely monitoring the evolving maritime security situation in the Persian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz, Gulf of Oman and adjoining sea areas
- » It said the threats of the recent geopolitical developments included missile

ing sea areas.

It said the threats of the recent geopolitical developments included missile and drone activity, electronic interference, and other maritime security concerns.

Stakeholders have been advised to maintain heightened vigilance and undertake voyage-specific risk assessments, and vessels operating in the region have been advised to maintain an enhanced security posture

and drone activity, electronic interference, and other maritime security concerns

- » The directorate further said that it has activated enhanced monitoring and security oversight, real-time tracking of Indian-flagged vessels with increased reporting frequency and 24X7 monitoring

are maintaining close coordination with all stakeholders to ensure their continued safety, well-being and timely support.

All necessary support, assistance and facilitation are being extended to the affected seafarers and their families, it added.

The directorate further said that it has activated enhanced monitoring and security oversight, real-time tracking of Indian-flagged vessels with increased reporting frequency and 24X7 monitoring.

Shipping companies have also been advised to exercise due caution in crew deployment and to maintain regular communication with seafarers and their families.

It said a dedicated 'quick response team' has also been formed to ensure timely coordination among all concerned authorities, enable immediate response to emerging situations, and facilitate prompt assistance and support to Indian seafarers and their families.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Harsh Baweja, former Director (Finance) and CFO of REC Limited, receives 'India's Most Influential CFO 2026 Award', while Alok Singh, Chief Program Manager, Regional Office - Mumbai, on behalf of REC, receives the Award for Excellence in CSR for Healthcare Access during the National Leadership Summit & Awards, on Feb 27 in Mumbai

'India adopts pragmatic approach to regulate AI'

NEW DELHI: India has adopted a balanced and pragmatic approach on AI, avoiding the extremes of lightly regulated US model and heavily compliance-driven framework of the European Union, said an Indian AI Research Organisation official.

Indian AI Research Organisation (IAIRO), Founding Director, Amit Sheth said India has adopted balanced regulatory approach which enables innovation while safeguarding users.

"India is adopting a pragmatic, balanced regulatory approach, avoiding both the lightly regulated model seen in the United States, which poses high risks to society, and the heavily compliance-driven framework of the European Union, which reduces innovation. The objective is to enable innovation while safeguarding users," Sheth told PTI in an e-mailed interview.

He said that the US leads in frontier AI research and large, proprietary, consumer-centric models, supported by deep capital markets, advanced semiconductor ecosystems, and hyperscale compute infra-

structure. He said China, despite export controls on advanced chips, has demonstrated that sovereign AI capability can still be built through coordinated investment in domestic infrastructure, efficient model design, and strong talent development.

"By focusing on increasingly capable and open models, China has narrowed the performance gap while strengthening full-stack resilience across compute, models, and deployment. India's opportunity lies elsewhere. Rather than replicating capital-intensive consumer AI, India can lead in high-value, industry- and domain-specific systems that address national priorities across sectors such as healthcare, agriculture, finance, and governance," he said.

IAIRO members include academicians from leading universities, entrepreneurs who have built successful AI startups, and technologists from Amazon, Meta, Apple, Netflix, and Snap.

Sheth said to build sovereign and trusted AI, India must strengthen its deep AI talent pipeline.

GDP GROWTH PROJECTION FOR FY27 RETAINED 7%

Middle East conflict to discourage investment into India and offset trade deal positives: BMI

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Fitch Group company BMI on Tuesday said that the ongoing conflict in the Middle East could discourage investment in India, and offset the positive effects of trade deals with the EU and US on GDP.

A 10 per cent rise in crude price could dent India's GDP by -0.3 to -0.6 percentage points, BMI said, adding net oil importers, especially in South Asia, would bear the brunt of the fallout in the US-Israel-Iran crisis.

In its India outlook report, BMI retained 7 per cent GDP growth projection for FY27 in view of the evolving geopolitical situation, lower than 7.9 per cent growth estimated in the current fiscal.

"From March onwards, we expect uncertainty to increase sharply due to the ongoing conflict in the Middle East. We believe this will discourage investment in India, off-

CLOSER LOOK

- » A 10 per cent rise in crude price could dent India's GDP by -0.3 to -0.6 percentage points, BMI said
- » Net oil importers, especially in South Asia, would bear the brunt of the fallout in the US-Israel-Iran crisis, it added
- » For India, high crude import dependence and fuel pass-through could



squeeze households and firms

- » India imports 88 per cent of its crude oil needs, and any rise in prices will swell its import bill as well as fuel inflation

setting the (EU and US) trade deals' positive effects on GDP," BMI said.

The US and Israel jointly launched military strikes on Iran on February 28. Iran responded by firing drones and missiles at Israel and US military installations around the Gulf, and also at the global business hub of Dubai.

Iran also hit energy facili-

ties in Qatar and Saudi Arabia, and on Tuesday announced the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, which could send global oil and natural gas prices soaring. The Strait is a narrow 33-kilometre passage connecting the Persian Gulf to the Arabian Sea.

Roughly a fifth of global seaborne crude transits Hormuz daily, and any sustained disruption would reverberate

through the economies most exposed to imported energy, BMI said.

For India, high crude import dependence and fuel pass-through could squeeze households and firms; and wider trade deficit and higher inflation would typically curb consumption and investment, making GDP hit relatively large, BMI said.

India imports 88 per cent of its crude oil needs, and any rise in prices will swell its import bill as well as fuel inflation.

BMI said retail fuel pricing decisions --- the speed and scale of pass through -- will determine whether the shock manifests as inflation or fiscal deterioration in India.

On the positive side, BMI said the new India-US trade deal and the US Supreme Court's striking down of the Trump administration's reciprocal tariffs could boost India's economy.

India and the US, early last month, agreed on a framework

to finalise an interim trade deal, under which Washington will cut down the tariffs to 18 per cent. To sign and implement the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement, the framework has to be converted into a legal document.

However, in February, the US Supreme Court ruled that the tariffs imposed by Trump on nations around the world were illegal and that the president had exceeded his authority when he imposed the sweeping levies by using the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) of 1977.

Following the court ruling, the US imposed 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days, effective from February 24. Trump has announced to increase it to 15 per cent, but there is no official order on that yet.

In January, India and the EU had agreed on a free trade agreement (FTA), which will be implemented within a year after legal ratification.

Power ministry to set up panel for selection of NTPC CMD

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Union Power ministry has decided to set up a search-cum-selection committee to look for the head of state-owned electricity generator NTPC, as government headhunter PESB failed to identify a suitable candidate.

The Public Enterprise Selection Board (PESB), under the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT), which is responsible for hiring candidates for top management posts of central public sector enterprises (CPSES), interviewed a dozen of candidates for the post of CMD of NTPC.

The incumbent, Gurdeep Singh, was to supersannate on July 31, 2025, but his service as NTPC's CMD was extended till August 1, 2026, in the absence of a successor.

The Power ministry, in a notice issued on February 28, said the appointment to the post of Chairman and Managing Director, NTPC Limited, will be done through a "Search-cum-selection Committee".

Candidates can apply for the post on or before March 28, 2026, it said.

The search-cum-selection committee route is taken when PESB fails to find a suitable candidate.

Since 2021, PESB has failed to find a suitable candidate for at least four other public sector enterprises -- Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC), Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Hindustan Petroleum Corporation (HPCL), and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL). Singh, too, was chosen to head NTPC by a search-cum-selection committee in 2016.

CAN UNLOCK RS 2.5L CRORE OF CPSES INVENTORY

Goyal calls for need to make India self-reliant in capital goods sector

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Tuesday underscored the need to make India self-reliant in the capital goods sector, saying areas such as container manufacturing can significantly support the country's export and import trade.

Addressing a post-Budget webinar on manufacturing, industrial upgrade and strategic sectors, he said there is a need to promote capital goods segment "very" rapidly as it can unlock nearly Rs 2.5 lakh crore of CPSEs inventory.

He said these are some of the major suggestions being made during the deliberations in three sub-groups.

Some of the interesting key takeaways of these deliberations include the need of talent and supplier confidence for full stack-up in the semicon-

HIGHLIGHTS

» Addressing a post-Budget webinar on manufacturing, industrial upgrade and strategic sectors, he said there is a need to promote capital goods segment 'very' rapidly

» Some of the interesting key takeaways of these deliberations include the need of talent and supplier confidence for full stack-up in the



semiconductor 2.0; and capital equipment, material localisation and specifically skill development for the electronics components sector

ductor 2.0; and capital equipment, material localisation and specifically skill development for the electronics components sector.

Goyal said Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh spoke a lot about machine manufacturing

in India and "it's high time we recognize the need to become self-sufficient in our requirements of capital goods".

India's machine tool imports grew 15 per cent to USD 5.43 billion during April-January 2025-26. During the

period, the country's imports of machinery, electrical and non-electrical increased 14.21 per cent to USD 50.8 billion.

The other suggestions include requirement of plug and play infrastructure and predictable clearances to fix the upstream import gaps for chemical parks; rapid promotion of the capital goods sector; for rare earth corridors, integration of mining to manufacturing; and need for demand for the Biopharma Shakti scheme.

He added that the textiles sector needs global scale and there is a need to move from cotton into MMF (man made fibre).

"We must look at digital handloom platforms to promote our handloom and handicraft sector -- I think now we need to move from thought to action, from plans to outcomes and from discussions

to action on the ground," Goyal said, adding things like container manufacturing, close to the ports, can really promote India's export-import business.

In the Union Budget, the government proposed three new dedicated Chemical Parks; and a scheme to revive 200 legacy industrial clusters.

The minister added that several sector-wise priorities have also emerged with greater clarity.

It includes process streamlining for speedy implementation; academia links skilling to create globally competitive talent; flexible land allocation to unlock investments; sustainability solutions such as addressing textiles water and reuse of that water; and innovative public private partnerships or special purpose vehicle models to harness the strengths of government private sector and state partnerships.

Qatar's force majeure disrupts gas supplies to Indian industry

NEW DELHI: Qatar, India's largest supplier of imported natural gas, has declared force majeure on deliveries following a halt in production in the wake of an Iranian drone strike -- a disruption that has led to a cut in supplies to Indian industry by up to 40 per cent, sources said.

Qatar supplies about 40 per cent of the nearly 27 million tonnes of liquefied natural gas (LNG) that India imports annually to meet demand across sectors ranging from power generation and fertiliser production to CNG distribution and piped cooking gas networks.

Gas importer Petronet LNG Ltd has informed gas marketers of Qatar halting its liquefied natural gas production after Iran continued to strike Gulf countries in retaliation for Israeli and US strikes against it, they said.

The attacks have also effectively brought oil and LNG shipments through the Strait of Hormuz to a near halt, driving up global energy prices as

CLOSER LOOK

» Qatar, India's largest supplier of imported natural gas, has declared force majeure on deliveries following a halt in production in the wake of an Iranian drone strike

» Gas importer Petronet

LNG Ltd has informed gas marketers of Qatar halting its liquefied natural gas production

» Qatar supplies about 40 per cent of the nearly 27 million tonnes of LNG that India imports annually to meet demand across sectors

well as sharply raising war-risk insurance and shipping costs.

Iran controls the Strait -- a vital maritime chokepoint through which roughly 50 per cent of India's crude oil imports and around 54 per cent of its LNG supplies transit. It is the transit for not just LNG from Qatar but also from the UAE.

Sources said Petronet has informed its gas offtakers, GAIL (India) Ltd and Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), about a halt in supplies from Qatar. The gas marketers have, in turn, cut supplies to industries while maintaining flow rates for CNG retailing.

The cuts range from 10 per cent to 40 per cent, they said.

Petronet has long term contract to buy 8.5 million tonnes per annum of LNG from Qatar.

Additionally, it buys Qatari LNG from the spot market as well. Besides Petronet, companies such as IOC have LNG import contracts with the UAE. Sources said GAIL and IOC are looking at tapping the spot or current market to meet the shortfall, but prices have firmed up. LNG in the spot market is now at USD 25 per million British thermal unit, roughly double the term contract rates.

AGENCIES

Ships' war risk insurance premiums 'likely to rise'

NEW DELHI: Freight carriers will have to pay an additional premium to restore war cover for shipments passing through high-risk areas amid the escalating crisis in West Asia, experts said.

Vessels of the Shipping Corporation of India (SCI) are also involved in the movement of crude oil and LNG, especially through areas around the Red Sea, and would have to pay an additional premium for war cover to ensure risk cover.

"It is reasonable to expect that Indian oil companies will have cargo exposures and SCI will have hull exposure in this region. Oil prices are also likely to face upward pressure in the near term," Policybazaar Head (marine insurance) Balasundaram R said.

According to Prudent Insurance Brokers Head (marine specialties), Gaurav Agarwal, notice of cancellation of war cover has been issued on hull on March 1, and a similar cancella-

tion on cargo is expected soon. After this cancellation, Agarwal said, the insurers may increase premiums on hull and cargo.

"If the conflict becomes a serious war risk, insurance premiums for ships are likely to go up, and insurance companies may adjust pricing quickly based on the risk level. Since cargo insurance premium is calculated based on cargo value, the total premium amount may go up, even if the rate stays the same," he said.

However, he said, unless the conflict becomes long and widespread, a major overall increase in insurance premiums across the board is unlikely.

Experts further said shipment or cargoes that have already sailed from India are anchoring in international waters, are waiting for the situation to ease out, and alternate routes are being worked on by shipping lines, which will add additional cost to the importer/exporter.

MPOST

India starts countervailing duty probe against imports of Chinese PVC resins

NEW DELHI: India has initiated a countervailing duty investigation against imports of Chinese PVC resins, used in multiple sectors including pipes, bottles, and cables, following complaints by domestic players.

The investigation the DGTR follows an application filed by Chemplast Cuddalore Vinyls, DCM Shriram and DCW Ltd. The applicants have alleged that China is subsidising its PVC Suspension Resin makers and those companies are dumping the goods into Indian markets at cheaper prices.

The Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR) is an arm of the Commerce ministry. "On the basis of the duly substantiated application by the domestic industry, and having satisfied itself, on the basis of the prima facie evidence submitted by the applicants

INSIGHT

» It has been alleged that China is subsidising its PVC Suspension Resin makers and those companies are dumping the goods into Indian markets at cheaper prices

» In a separate notification, the DGTR said that it has also started an anti-absorption investigation of the anti-dumping duty imposed on imports

of a Chinese herbicide, Glufosinate and its salts

» Superform Chemisuiies, UPI Ltd, Astral Life India, United Phosphorus (India) LLP and UPL Sustainable Agri Solution have filed an application before the DGTR, alleging absorption of anti-dumping duty imposed on the imports from China

» 'The authority, hereby, initiates an anti-absorption investigation...'

substantiating the existence of subsidization and consequent injury to the domestic industry, the authority hereby initiates an anti-subsidy investigation," the DGTR has said in a notification.

The directorate will determine the existence, degree, and effect of the alleged sub-

sidisation and recommend the amount of countervailing duty, which, if levied, would be adequate to remove the injury to the domestic industry.

The applicants have alleged that the producers/exporters of the goods in China have benefited from the subsidies provided at various levels by the

SLATED TO BE HELD FROM OCT 7-10

Scindia unveils 10th edition of India Mobile Congress

NEW DELHI: Union Telecom Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia has unveiled the 10th edition of telecom industry event India Mobile Congress to be held from October 7-10 this year, according to a statement on Tuesday.

The dates were unveiled at global telecom event Mobile World Congress 2026 being held at Barcelona in Spain.

"As India completes a decade of telecom transformation, India Mobile Congress

also enters the 10th edition, enabling global launches, startup discovery, partnerships and industry-government collaboration," Scindia said while unveiling the dates.

According to the statement issued by organisers of the India Mobile Congress (IMC), Scindia said the IMC's journey mirrors India's own digital journey from connectivity to intelligence and from access to impact and this edition will showcase AI-native networks,

smart industries, sovereign platforms, startup innovation and global partnerships."

"India is among a small group of nations to develop its own indigenous, cloud-native 4G stack, upgradeable to 5G, positioning us not only as users of advanced networks, but as builders of them. It is emerging as a trusted global source for telecom products, platforms and solutions," the minister said. Organised by the Department of Telecommunications

and the industry body Cellular Operators' Association of India (COAI), IMC 2026 will bring together policymakers, industry leaders, global enterprises, startups, and investors from over 100 countries. As part of deeper collaboration, the GSMA Board will participate in IMC 2026, lending their global expertise and strengthening the forum's international reach.

"India has firmly established itself as a global telecom leader, not only through the scale and

speed of its 5G rollout, but through its ambition in 6G, AI and digital innovation," Julian Gorman, Head of Asia Pacific, GSMA said.

"Through our enhanced role at India Mobile Congress 2026, the GSMA is bringing its global network of operators and industry leaders together to deepen collaboration, share best practice and reinforce India's position at the centre of the global digital ecosystem," Gorman said.

MPOST

GST: ₹6.37 cr demand notice slapped on Britannia



NEW DELHI: GST authorities have issued a demand notice of Rs 6.37 crore to Britannia Industries, and the company is exploring legal remedies.

'The order has been passed under Section 74 of the GST Act for FY 2020-21 to FY 2023-24'

The bakery food company received the order from the Office of the Commissioner of CGST & Central Excise, Thane on Monday, according to a regulatory filing from the company. The order has been passed under Section 74 of the GST Act for FY 2020-21 to FY 2023-24, alleging non-payment of tax due to "incorrect classification" of goods supplied.

"The tax and penalty quantified in the order amount to Rs 2,12,40,000 and Rs 4,24,80,000 respectively, totalling to a demand of Rs 6,37,20,000 in addition to the applicable interest," Britannia said.

However, this will have "no material impact on the financials, operations or other activities" of the company, said Britannia, which owns popular brands such as Good Day, Tiger, NutriChoice and MarieGold. "The order is appealable and the company shall take necessary actions, including exercising the legal remedies available under the GST law," said Britannia Industries.

MPOST

Regulator monitoring short-tenor Options; Futures stable: Sebi chief

MUMBAI: Sebi chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said the regulator has no concerns over the futures segment of the derivatives market, but remains watchful of speculative activity in short-dated options.

Pandey said the regulator's recent interventions are focused specifically on curbing excesses in short-tenor options, while preserving the crucial role of futures and derivatives in price discovery and liquidity.

Responding to a question on the derivatives segment, Pandey said the issue should not be broadly labelled as one concerning F&O. "You should not be calling it F&O because futures we never had an issue with. There was an issue around short-dated options," he said in an interaction with PTI.

He noted that Sebi has already introduced a series of regulatory measures targeting excesses in short-tenor options. Measures were rolled out in October 2024 and May 2025, with phased implementation in July, October and December. The regulator is now assessing the impact of these interventions based on market data. "We are looking at what impact

He noted that Sebi has already introduced a series of regulatory measures targeting excesses in short-tenor options

it has based on data. If we think there is still a need for intervention, we will look at different pathways to achieve that goal and have another round of consultations," he said.

Pandey emphasised that Sebi does not intend to "flip-flop" on the issue or take broad-brush actions. Instead, the regulator aims to identify specific problem areas and address them in a calibrated manner.

Short-dated options, especially zero-day-to-expiry contracts, are derivatives that expire either the same day or within a few days. They are cheap and offer high leverage, which allows traders to bet on or hedge against very short-term market movements. However, these instruments are extremely volatile and lose value very quickly,

making them highly risky for retail investors.

Sebi chief highlighted that the futures market and the broader derivatives segment play a crucial role in price discovery and liquidity.

"It is better we concentrate on the problem areas which Sebi itself identified and also put out the data. We issued statutory warnings, introduced measures, and will continue to analyse their impact. This is the path we will follow," he added.

Earlier in July, Sebi also expressed concern over the growing dominance of ultra-short-term derivatives trading, cautioning that such trends could undermine the health of India's capital markets.

Responding to suggestions that people from the lower-income strata should be kept out of derivatives trading, the Sebi chief said the regulator receives numerous recommendations from various quarters.

"Everybody can make suggestions. We receive plenty of suggestions through emails and social media, one way or the other," he said, without indicating any immediate move on the proposal.

PTI

'Hiring in India rises 12% in Feb on AI push & IT sector recovery'

Non-IT sectors continue to anchor the hiring momentum

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: India's white-collar job market recorded a 12 per cent year-on-year growth in February, amid increasing AI adoptions and a recovery in the IT sector, a report said on Tuesday.

White-collar job market posted its strongest February performance in recent years, with the Naukri JobSpeak Index reaching 3,233 points - up 12 per cent from 2,890 points in February 2025.

The month-on-month acceleration from January to February came in at 23 per cent, noticeably sharper than the 13-16 per cent range typically seen between the two months, the report based on Naukri JobSpeak Index added.

The IT sector posted over 6 per cent year-on-year growth in hiring in February 2026.

Freshers' hiring in the sector also grew by a healthy 8 per cent.



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

India-based multi-national IT companies were the primary driver, recording a 55 per cent hiring surge, the report said.

Within the IT sector, it said that AI/ML (artificial intelligence/machine learning) hiring rose 40 per cent, reinforcing that February performance was concentrated in highest-skill, highest-value talent segments.

The Naukri JobSpeak is a monthly index that tracks trends in India's job market and hiring activity, based on new job postings and recruiter searches on Naukri.com's

resume database. The report further said that freshers' hiring grew 17 per cent annually, while the demand for roles in the Rs 20 lakh-per-annum band rose 23 per cent, reflecting strength across both entry-level and high-value talent segments.

Meanwhile, non-IT sectors continued to anchor the hiring momentum, with insurance leading at 28 per cent, followed by BPO/ITES (22 per cent), real estate (19 per cent), hospitality/travel (15 per cent) and retail (14 per cent).

KEY POINTS

» White-collar job market posted its strongest February performance in recent years

» The IT sector posted over 6 per cent year-on-year growth in hiring in February 2026

In February 2026, Indian MNCs expanded hiring by 24 per cent. In the IT sector, AI/ML roles sustained their strong trajectory, rising 49 per cent year-on-year.

Indian MNCs grew their AI/ML hiring by 82 per cent, compared to 43 per cent for foreign MNCs, the report said, highlighting that domestic enterprises are placing their biggest bets in the adoption of the new technology. IT hiring is recovering meaningfully, and Indian MNCs are investing in AI talent at a healthy pace.



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

TAKEAWAYS

» On Tuesday, the price for a barrel of Brent crude, the international standard, leapt another 7.8% to \$83.84

» A barrel of benchmark US crude, meanwhile, rose 8.8% to \$77.52

» Oil prices made the jump as Iran struck the US Embassy in Saudi Arabia

the United States possesses.

The jump for oil prices will worsen inflation, which has remained too high for nearly everyone, and put more pressure on US households and businesses by raising bills for gasoline and to ship products.

The average price for a gallon of gasoline in the US jumped 11 cents overnight to about \$3.11, according to data from motor club AAA.

That has the damage in stock markets so far centering on countries and companies that use a lot of oil, natural gas and petroleum-based fuels.

MPOST

Battle of skippers

Markram vs Santner: Captains hold key to Proteas semis against NZ

KOLKATA: South African skipper Aiden Markram will be asked probing questions by his New Zealand counterpart Mitchell Santner in what promises to be an intriguing battle between two incredibly talented captains' in the first semifinal of the T20 World Cup here on Wednesday.

Not often does one find that captains of either side end up being the most prolific performers and Markram vs Santner will be such battle that would keep the near capacity crowd at the Eden Gardens on the edge. The ICC event rivalry between New Zealand and South Africa reached its peak during the 50-over World Cup semifinal in 2015 when the Black Caps edged out the Proteas in a nail-biting showdown with likes of Dale Steyn and AB de Villiers left scarred for life.

However, South Africa, under the tutelage of Shukri Conrad, has developed into a menacing side, having already won the World Test Championship last year showing steely resolve. While they haven't won a major white-ball trophy so far, the infamous chokers' tag isn't a part of their cricketing dictionary anymore.

At the core of this battle are the two captains, not often the most celebrated or talked about



South Africa's captain Aiden Markram inspects the pitch

PTI

but tactically and technically much better than all those who are feted way more.

Markram, with a strike rate of 175 plus and 268 runs, has had a devastating effect on rival bowlers during powerplay overs while Santner, with an economy rate of 6.35, has kept the batters tied in knots.

The Proteas, with a power-hitting line-up comprising Markram, Quinton De Kock, Dewald Brevis, Ryan Rickleton, Tristan Stubbs, David Miller and Marco Jansen, can give any team sleepless nights.

But Santner will have Rachin Ravindra (9 wickets at less than 7 ER), Glenn Phillips, Cole McConchie, who have all

268
Markram has so far scored 268 runs in the tournament at a handsome strike-rate of 175.16 with three fifties

performed in unison. Save for India, this is the best spin attack that Proteas would face in the tournament

although England with Liam Dawson and Rehan Ahmed wasn't bad either.

What New Zealand lack is a quality wrist spinner to challenge South Africa as Ish Sodhi hasn't exactly been great in the few games that he has played so far. On a belter of an Eden Gardens track, South Africa would like to chase against a New Zealand line up which played its Super Eights games on the slowish Sri Lankan tracks.

The belter at Eden will allow Finn Allen, Tim Seifert, Glenn Phillips and Daryl Mitchell to at least think of a 200-plus total that would give them a chance to contain the Proteas.

AGENCIES

Markram relishing the batter in him

KOLKATA: Aiden Markram has never been better as a batsman in T20Is than in the ongoing World Cup, but for that to happen, the South African skipper had to train his mind to shut the "captain" in him every time he went out to bat.

Markram, who has found his calling as an opener in T20Is, has so far scored 268 runs in the tournament at a very handsome strike-rate of 175.16 with three fifties, including one against the New Zealand in a group league game.

So has he been able to segregate the batter from the captain? "It's something that I have fought with a lot over the years. Just being the batter while you're out there batting. But I think you as the captain always want to get the team over the line," Markram said, speaking about his internal conflict.

AGENCIES

HAVE REACHED 5TH SUCCESSIVE SEMI-FINAL
Will powered! Eng ride chaos, craft to make another WC semis

MEENAKSHI RAO

MUMBAI: There are smoother teams in this T20 World Cup, and there are more dominant ones. But few enter the last four as intriguing — or as dangerous — as England, who have stitched together a campaign built on late-order nerve, new-ball precision and a stubborn refusal to play the same game twice.

Their progress has not been founded on perfection. The top-order has flickered, partnerships have rarely settled, and their best XI still feels fluid rather than fixed. Yet England have won six of seven matches and reached a fifth successive semi-final — a remarkable stretch of consistency in cricket's most volatile format, suggesting something sturdier than passing form.

At the centre of that resilience stands Will Jacks, arguably the tournament's most influential all-rounder. Batting at No. 7, Jacks has scored 162 runs in the death overs — the most by any player in the competition — and 191 overall, the highest tally by anyone outside the top four. With the ball, he has provided vital overs of off-spin, frequently serving as the sixth option behind captain Harry Brook's frontline attack.



Will Jacks has been crucial to England's design

PTI

His four Player-of-the-Match awards already equal Shane Watson's record for a single men's T20 World Cup. More telling is the timing: against Nepal, Italy, Sri Lanka and New Zealand, his interventions have turned drift into control, vulnerability into command.

If Jacks has finished games, Jofra Archer has shaped their beginnings. After an expensive start to the tournament, Archer has rediscovered his bite with the new ball, taking eight of his 10 wickets in the powerplay. England's 18 powerplay wickets rank among the tournament's best, and Archer's 66 dot balls in the first six overs underline how effectively he has choked opponents at the outset.

The one unresolved element remains top-order. Phil

Salt and Jos Buttler have averaged just 12 as an opening pair, while the top six's collective average of 21.9 is among the lowest of the semifinalists. Starts have been frequent; substantial scores, scarce. Yet England's campaign has thrived on different match-winners emerging at different moments. Brook's century against Pakistan remains their most complete batting display, while the lower order — led by Jacks and supported by Sam Curran — has repaired early damage.

Now they return to the Wankhede Stadium for a semifinal against India, a ground of mixed memories: defeat to West Indies earlier in this tournament, and a heavy loss to India in a bilateral series last year.

AFC WOMEN'S ASIAN CUP

Undercooked India face Vietnam test



India have not played a single international game this year

AIFF

PERTH: The lack of international game time could haunt India when they face higher-ranked Vietnam in their opening group match of the AFC Women's Asian Cup football tournament here on Wednesday.

Ranked lowest in the group of four teams, the others being Japan and Chinese Taipei, India have not played a single international match this year. The last time they played an international match was in October 2025, against Iran and Nepal, which they lost 0-2 and 1-2 respectively.

Instead of playing international matches, India opted to play against club sides during a four-week camp in Turkey from where the Blue Tigresses arrived in Perth on February 11. Since then, the Indian team played friendly matches against two Australian club sides.

There was a November FIFA international match window but India did not play any matches.

Amelia Valverde, Costa Rica's head coach at the 2015 and 2023 FIFA Women's World Cups, took charge only in January after Crispin Chhetri, who is currently assistant coach, was at the helm during the qualification round. Vietnam, on the other hand, have played four

“We could not finish the group stage four years ago but we are back here again and have a chance to prove ourselves”
— Amelia Valverde, India's coach

international matches in February, two each against Uzbekistan and China, both strong sides in the continent, winning once and losing thrice.

Ranked 36 in the FIFA list as against 67 of India, Vietnam women's team has been a rising force, having qualified for the 2023 FIFA Women's World Cup. They also reached the quarter-finals of the previous edition of the Asian Cup.

Vietnam have also won both their previous clashes against India in the AFC Women's Asian Cup, both in the group stage, scoring multiple goals on both occasions (3-0 and 2-1). However, this will be the first meeting between the two sides in the competition since 2003.

AGENCIES

Mandhana climbs to top of ODI rankings

DUBAI: India opener Smriti Mandhana on Tuesday climbed to the top of the ICC Women's ODI Batting Rankings following her fine performances in the just-concluded three-match series against Australia.

Mandhana (790 points) made notable scores of 58 and 31 in the series, doing enough to move past South Africa's Laura Wolvaardt (782), who will have the opportunity to reclaim the spot when the Proteas take on New Zealand across March and April.

Making a century in her final ODI, Alyssa Healy signed off in fourth place on the rankings (744), wedged between Beth Mooney (749) and Ashleigh Gardner (724).

India captain Harmanpreet Kaur is the other Indian in top 10 at ninth position, while Jemimah Rodrigues is on 12th.

Despite losing all three matches of the ODI series, there was joy for Harmanpreet (652), who moved four spots back into the top 10 for batters, thanks to scores of 53, 54 and 25.

Deepti Sharma is the lone Indian in top 10 among bowlers at the 10th spot.

AGENCIES

Women's cricket team in line for Laureus

MADRID: In a first, the Indian women's cricket squad has been nominated for the prestigious 2026 Laureus World Team of the Year Award following their maiden World Cup title triumph.

The nomination was confirmed by Laureus Sport on Tuesday.

They are the first women's cricket team to receive this nomination, a recognition for their exceptional performance in the mega event, including the highest successful run chase in women's ODI history in a semi-final win against Australia.

The Harmanpreet Kaur-led side is nominated alongside major teams like the England Women's football team, European Ryder Cup squad, French football league's Paris Saint-Germain, and McLaren Formula 1.

Laureus Sport said in a press release: "In their Cricket World Cup semi-final against Australia, the India Women's Cricket Team pulled off the highest successful run chase in women's ODI history (339) — before winning their first title against South Africa and are the first women's cricket team to be nominated for this Award."

AGENCIES



NZ's Ish Sodhi with Mitchell Santner during training on Tuesday

PTI

Manchester United returned to the Premier League's top three for the first time since May 2023

titles remain the World Test Championship crown and the 2000 Champions Trophy triumph, but their consistency at global events is noteworthy. This is their fourth T20 World Cup semifinal appearance -- after 2007, 2016 and 2022 -- while they have twice finished runners-up in ODI World Cups (2015 and 2019).

Santner acknowledged that his team is familiar with being

dubbed as underdogs.

"We are kind of used to the tag now. It's whether you want to call it the underdogs or not. I think for us, it's everyone's goal that throughout the tournament to get to the stage. We're here now, and we back ourselves to adapt as quick as we can to what's in front of us."

"I think at this stage, it's just knockout game, and that's it at the end of the day, and whoever really turns up is going to get through," he added.

The left-arm spinner underlined that controlling South Africa's explosive batting would be central to their plans. "There's no real hiding, or secrets about what South Africa are going to bring and they probably know what we do as well."

AGENCIES

Real lose again to give Barca breathing space



LONDON: Real Madrid lost a second straight La Liga match when a stunning volley from Martin Satriano gave Getafe a shock 1-0 win at Santiago Bernabeu Stadium on Monday.

The result prevented the capital club from cutting the four-point gap to leaders Barcelona.

Getafe had lost all eight of its previous league encounters with Real Madrid and early saves from goalkeeper David Soria kept it from falling behind.

Soria turned over a shot from Arda Güler midway through the first half, not long after frustrating Vinicius Junior when he was through on goal.

Madrid had more of the ball but lacked punch up front and it paid a price for its profligacy six minutes before half-time when Getafe took the lead.

A hopeful cross from the right was headed clear but it

fell to the feet of Satriano, who volleyed into the roof of the net from 20 meters out.

It was the second goal in three games for the Uruguayan, who joined on loan from Lyon during the last transfer window. Madrid continued to dominate possession in the second half and Antonio Rüdiger and substitute Rodrygo were among those who came close to grabbing an equalizer.

But it could not find a way past Getafe's stuffy rearguard and an in-form Soria.

Madrid's task became even harder when Franco Mastantuono was sent off for dissent in stoppage time and although the numbers were evened up in the last minute when Getafe's Adrian Liso was also shown a red card it came too late to make any impact. Getafe held on to secure a historic win, its first at the Santiago Bernabeu since 2008.

AGENCIES

Prague Masters: Gukesh to meet Aravindh

PRAGUE: Desperately seeking his first victory in the tournament, reigning world champion D Gukesh will take on compatriot Aravindh Chithambaram in the sixth round of the Masters section of the Prague International Chess Festival on Wednesday.

With just 1.5 points coming through three draws and a couple of losses, this is another slump for Gukesh that saw him slip to number 17 in the live world rankings. The world champion needs to make adjustments quickly before it's too late in the event.

Gukesh's first loss was against tournament leader Jordan van Foreest, where he was doing well until a certain point, while his second defeat against Nodirbek Abdusattorov was a positional mistake under time pressure.

Gukesh is set to play Iranian Parham Maghsoodloo, Vincent Keymer of Germany and David Anton Guijarro of Spain in the last three rounds.

Aravindh has had a lone victory but that was also from a worse position against American Hans Moke Niemann. The Indian defending champion broke into top-level chess right here last year after winning this tournament, but his struggles this year make Gukesh a huge favorite in their clash.

AGENCIES

Iran's World Cup place put in doubt by war; FIFA has Iraq next in line

GENEVA: Iran's place at the men's World Cup in three months was put in doubt amid an escalating Middle East conflict sparked by the soccer tournament's co-host the United States.

Iran are due to play their three group stage games in the U.S. — two in Inglewood, California, then in Seattle — from June 15-26. Cities in Canada and Mexico also will host some of the 104 games.

The US and Israel have targeted Iran in coordinated attacks since Saturday that killed Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and dozens more senior officials.

It provoked an Iranian response that aimed missiles at US allies including 2022 World Cup host Qatar and Saudi Arabia, which FIFA has picked to stage the 2034 edition.



Iran's fans during a match

AFP

"What is certain is that after this attack, we cannot be expected to look forward to the World Cup with hope," said Iran's top soccer official Mehdi Taj, a vice president of the

Asian Football Confederation.

It is unclear if the state-backed Iranian soccer federation could refuse to send its team to the 48-nation tournament that starts June 11, or the

They are No. 20 in the FIFA world rankings of 211 teams, and have not been lower than No. 24

U.S. government could effectively block the team.

FIFA has declined comment since Saturday, when secretary general Mattias Grafström said it would "monitor developments around all issues around the world."

The White House's top official overseeing World Cup preparations, Andrew Giuliani,

AGENCIES



‘No excuse for online bullying against Arjun’

Janhvi Kapoor maintained that such actions can't be justified

Although Janhvi Kapoor is a sport and takes criticism and trolling on social media in good spirit, she recently attested that there are times when people cross the line and insensitively attack the likes of her, meting out blatant harassment. Referring to the online

bullying that her stepbrother, actor Arjun Kapoor, frequently faces, she maintained that such actions can't be justified. She pointed out that the only way to avoid being affected by these attacks is, however, to steer clear of them and not take things to heart.

Janhvi also stated that, in her experience, people create and share such content on social media simply for audience engagement and not to actually sling mud at the celebrity in focus. "From what I understand about social media culture, everyone wants prominence, views and virality. So, if they are making content about you, you're just a scapegoat; they're just using your name for clickbait, rage bait and whatever else it is to further their engagement. That's the only purpose you serve, and once you look at it from that lens, you understand that what they're saying about you has nothing to do with you. Then you start taking that less to your heart," she shared during a conversation with 'Grazia'.

Further maintaining that there's no point in being sensitive about



such things, as they are most often pointless, she added, "Everyone's doing what they have to. Sab ghar chalne ki koshish kar rahe hai. You need to be transactional; nothing is that deep. It's stupid to occupy your brain for more than five minutes with this."

Janhvi, nonetheless, admitted that social media negativity can be upsetting at times when it crosses the line into harassment, which she said she has seen happen with her stepbrother, Arjun Kapoor. "Of course, it hurts to feel misunderstood or when it turns into bullying and harassment, the way I've seen happen with my brother sometimes. There's no excuse for that kind of behaviour."

AGENCIES

‘Never played someone as unhinged’

Aditya Rawal talked about playing an unpredictable character in 'Subedaar'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Over the years, Aditya Rawal has carved a distinct niche for himself, portraying intense, morally complex characters, most recently leaving a mark as Sajid in Prime Video's 'Daldal'. But in 'Subedaar', he steps into a darker territory as the formidable Prince, a volatile antagonist who squares off against Anil Kapoor's Subedaar Arjun Maurya in the much-awaited action-drama film. The trailer offers striking glimpses of simmering tension and sudden bursts of aggression by the mobster, hinting at a character driven by power, insecurity and the constant need for validation.

Speaking about stepping into Prince's fractured psyche, Aditya shared, "Honestly, in the past, I've played quite a few characters with grey shades. I've played gangsters. I've played a terrorist and I've played young men who've strayed from their path. But I've never played somebody as unhinged and depraved as Prince."

But what drew him in wasn't just the darkness. It was the fragility beneath it. Aditya added, "What really struck me was his vulnerability. Basically, this person does what he does for attention and to prove that he is capable of being the king. That inferiority complex drives everything. If he asserts power,



What drew the actor in wasn't just the darkness. It was the fragility beneath it

it's because he's trying to prove he's no less than Mona Singh's character, Babli didi. The more insecure he feels, the more he explodes. That level of insecurity was what made him most interesting to me."

'Subedaar' is directed by Suresh Triveni, known for his acclaimed storytelling in 'Tumhari Sulu', 'Jalsa' and 'Daldal' and is produced by Vikram Malhotra, Anil Kapoor and Suresh Triveni. Starring Anil Kapoor and Radhika Madan in the lead roles, alongside Saurabh Shukla, Aditya Rawal, Faisal Malik, Mona Singh and Khushboo Sundar in pivotal roles, it'll premiere on 'Prime Video' on March 5.

‘Scary Movie’ franchise returns after 26 years

The original film was a massive commercial success, grossing over USD 278 million worldwide

Cult horror-comedy franchise 'Scary Movie' is set to return with its sixth part, set to be released in Indian theatres on June 12, 'Paramount Pictures India' announced.

The film reunites the original core cast - Marlon Wayans, Shawn Wayans, Anna Faris and Regina Hall - reprising their roles as Shorty, Ray, Cindy and Brenda respectively, 26 years after the original film became a global comedy phenomenon.

Directed by Michael Tiddes, the new instalment takes aim at the current wave of horror reboots, remakes, prequels, sequels, origin stories and what the makers describe as 'every final chapter that absolutely isn't final', a press release said.

The ensemble cast also includes Damon Wayans Jr., Kim Wayans, Gregg Wayans, Cheri Oteri, Chris Elliott, Dave Sheridan, Heidi Gardner, Lochlyn Munro, Olivia Rose Keegan, Ruby Snowber, Savannah Lee Nassif, Sydney Park, Benny Zielke and Cameron Scott Roberts.

The filmmakers have described the project as a broad-

The sixth part will be released in Indian theatres on June 12

range parody that spares no contemporary horror sub-genre, from elevated horror to 'legacy sequels', with the Wayans brothers promising that 'nothing is sacred'.

The 'Scary Movie' franchise, created by the Wayans brothers, launched in 2000 as a parody of late 1990s slasher films, primarily targeting 'Scream' and 'I Know What You Did Last Summer'.

The original film was a massive commercial success, grossing over USD 278 million worldwide. It was followed by five instalments, with the Wayans brothers departing after the second film.

'Scary Movie' three and four, directed by David Zucker, shifted the parody targets to films like 'The Ring', 'Signs' and 'War of the Worlds', while the fifth instalment arrived in 2013, featuring Ashley Tisdale and Simon Rex.



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Holiday Inn New Delhi Mayur Vihar Noida announces a special culinary collaboration with Crowne Plaza Today Gurugram to present an exclusive four-day food pop-up of its celebrated restaurant, Kaansa. Known for its modern Indian cuisine inspired by India's iconic brass cookware, Kaansa brings its distinctive flavours, authenticity and artistic presentations to Café On 3 at Holiday Inn

New Delhi Mayur Vihar Noida from March 6 to March 9, 12:30 pm - 11 pm.

The pop-up is helmed by Sous Chef Ravinder Singh, who brings Kaansa's signature philosophy to life, honouring traditional Indian recipes while elevating them through modern culinary artistry. This limited-time culinary showcase features specially curated set menus that offer a refined journey through India's rich culinary heritage, reimagined with contemporary finesse, featuring both vegetarian and non-vegetarian delicacies. Guests can savour signature creations, including Dal Kaansa, Gulab Jamun Ki Sabzi, Kaala Mutton Curry, Badami Murgh Shorba, Misthi Doi Brulee and other distinctive specialties curated exclusively for this showcase.

Ashutosh Bisht, Executive Chef, Holiday Inn New Delhi Mayur Vihar Noida, shared, "We are delighted with this collaboration to bring the cele-



brated flavours of Kaansa to Café On 3 restaurants. This pop-up presents a unique opportunity for our guests to experience regional Indian cuisine, expertly crafted with exceptional creativity and authenticity. At Holiday Inn New Delhi Mayur Vihar Noida, we continuously strive to curate memorable dining experiences and this showcase

perfectly embodies that vision." Sankha Dasmahapatra, Executive Chef, Crowne Plaza Today Gurugram, added, "Kaansa is inspired by India's culinary legacy and the warmth of traditional brass cookware that enhances both flavour and experience. Bringing Kaansa to Holiday Inn New Delhi Mayur Vihar Noida allows us to share our

Culinary Showcase:
Kaansa Food Pop-Up
Venue:
Café On 3 Restaurant,
Holiday Inn New Delhi
Mayur Vihar Noida
Duration:
March 6 - March 9
Available For:
12:30 pm - 11 pm
Menu:
Specially Curated
Set Menu

signature creations with a wider audience. Each dish in this pop-up menu tells a story rooted in tradition yet elevated with contemporary techniques."

This exclusive four-day showcase promises to be a must-visit for gourmands seeking an immersive Indian dining experience that celebrates authenticity, craftsmanship and innovation.

‘I drew a lot from my uncle for Ikkis character’

Vivaan Shah was recently seen in the film directed by Sriram Raghavan

Vivaan Shah said it was a blessing to portray a real-life character like Captain Vijendra Malhotra in filmmaker Sriram Raghavan's war drama 'Ikkis' and a significant part of his performance was inspired by his uncle, retired Lieutenant General Zameeruddin Shah.

In the critically acclaimed war drama, which centres on India's youngest Param Vir Chakra awardee Arun Khetrapal, who was martyred during the 1971 Indo-Pak war, Shah played his sharp and composed senior officer, Captain Malhotra. His performance has been lauded for offering a counterpoint to Khetrapal's raw intensity as a battle-ready greenhorn officer.

Shah, son of veteran actors Naseeruddin Shah and Ratna Pathak Shah, said he has always been enamoured by his uncle's dynamic and formidable personality.



The actor said it was a blessing to portray a real-life character like Captain Vijendra Malhotra

"I based the character, a great deal of it, on my father's older brother, Lieutenant General Zameeruddin Shah, who actually fought in the Battle of Longewala. He's a very dynamic personality. And I really sort of drew on that a great deal and also from the real-life Captain Vijendra Malhotra, who himself was an extraordinarily charismatic person. I never, of course, got to meet him,

unfortunately. But I studied his photographs and the information available," Shah told PTI in an interview.

The film, which recently started streaming on 'Prime Video' following its release in theatres in January, features Agastya Nanda, Dharmendra and Jaideep Ahlawat.

The actor said that while he tried his best to authentically depict Malhotra in a 'truthful and honest' manner, a lot of it required him to fill in with his imagination. "This is the first time I've really got to play a really dynamic, smart and cool figure. And that, for me, was a real blessing," he said.

AGENCIES

